NO. 156 · SINGAPORE

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

SUNDAY 8 NOVEMBER 2026 · THE DEEPAVALI EDITION



THREE WERE MADE WITH THIS DIAL. ONE WAS MADE IN PINK GOLD (P10)

THE GOOD LIFE

A 2002 F.P. Journe beat a 1945 steel Patek by 2.4 million francs in Geneva

THE RABBIT HOLE

UNESCO's evaluators recommend inscribing shodō, as Japan loses 830,000 practitioners in five years

THE TRAVEL DESK

Japan's crane left the endangered list, and eastern Hokkaido's feeding stations are being unwound

Source: Phillips — lot 7, The Geneva Watch Auction: XXIV, catalogue photograph. Platinum Chronomètre à Résonance "Régence", 2002, sold 7 November 2026.

THIS ISSUE · NO. 156

Contents

p3 The World — the blockade goes ashore, and a seafarer dies
p4 The World — sixty-seven recommendations, forty-eight of them usable
p5 Singapore — two breaches, and not one number
p6 The Atelier — the valve is the whole product
p7 Technology — forty-one ballots, forty against
p8 The Home Lab — five dollars a month to reach your own fridge
p9 The Kit — a tilt-shift at f/2, and nobody has measured it
p10 The Good Life — a living maker outbids a dead one
p11 Screen & Sound — Godzilla's record opening day
p12–13 The Family Desk — the quietest age band, and a height myth
p14 The Macro Desk — the rally that was really an oil price
p15–17 The Rabbit Hole — shodō, and a ladder that takes eight years
p18 Fitness — the trial that missed and won anyway
p19–22 The Travel Desk — a cabin for 2027; a crane dispersing
p23–24 The Diary — three dates finally published, six dinners unjudged
p25–27 The Long Read — India meters the gig worker at fifty paise

NOT YET IN FORCE. Almost everything in this issue has been decided and not yet done. A treaty ratified and ungazetted (p4). A mandate announced for tonight (p4). Seven hundred million restrained and nobody charged for it (p5). A rate rise priced at seventy-three per cent (p14). And a levy passed in 2020 whose rate has never been notified (p25).

FROM THE DESK

"… we find beauty not in the thing itself, but in the patterns of shadows, the light and darkness, that one thing against another creates…"

Jun'ichirō Tanizaki, *In Praise of Shadows* **(1933)**[1]

Fitting for the festival of lights, and for p15, where a craft made entirely of soot and paper waits on a committee in Xiamen.

THE STRIP · AT FRIDAY'S CLOSE

US 10-year[2]	4.86%	▼ 5bp wk
US 10-year real[2]	2.63%	▲ 1bp wk
VWRA	$184.98	▼ 1.89%
AGGU	$5.84	▲ 0.69%
Gold[3]	$4,074.90	▲ 4.51%
Bitcoin[3]	$75,572	▼ 0.31%
Brent	$98.32	▼ 16.4%
USD/SGD	1.2825	▲ 0.35%
Straits Times	5,179.17	▼ 3.67%

Brent fell sixteen per cent and the ten-year barely moved (p14). Gold is a futures settle and bitcoin a snapshot. Not advice.[3]

FROM THE ARCHIVE · SUNDAY

No. 74, 16 August 2026, retired the Property page. It was the book's most-skipped, and the reader said so. What replaced it was The Atelier, which has since run eighty-three purchase categories to their makers — hats last night, pressure cookers this morning (p6).

The rule that page established still decides this one. Cover the mechanism, not the badge. Today it is a spring holding a poppet shut against a calibrated pressure, which is the only part of a pressure cooker that is not a pot.

And the ledger it created has started refusing things. Three of the categories proposed to this desk in the past fortnight collided with ones already covered, which is how a daily magazine discovers it has been going for a while.

SOURCES 1 Jun'ichirō Tanizaki, *In Praise of Shadows* (陰翳礼讃, 1933); the sentence is quoted from the standard English translation by Thomas J. Harper and Edward G. Seidensticker (Leete's Island Books, 1977), read at source in an online edition that reproduces it with ellipses at both ends, which are preserved here. 2 The United States Treasury's own daily par and real yield-curve files for November 2026, read at source; **the weekly change is measured Monday 2 November to Friday 6 November, the November table beginning on the 2nd** (p14). 3 Levels at Friday 6 November's close, each sourced instrument by instrument on p14. **Gold is a December futures settle rather than a London fix; bitcoin trades continuously and its close is a snapshot, shown here as its move on the day against the monthly move given on p14; the equity and bond weekly moves are this desk's arithmetic on two read closes.**

THE WORLD · THE STRAIT OF HORMUZ

CENTCOM takes its Iran blockade ashore as a seafarer dies in the Gulf

Task Force Iron Gate went after Iranian land and Caspian routes on 7 November. IMF PortWatch logged one transit of the strait on 1 November, against a pre-war 85 a day.

United States Central Command announced a task force on Saturday to cut off Iran's remaining overland and Caspian Sea shipments, extending onto dry land a naval blockade that has already emptied the Strait of Hormuz. Admiral Brad Cooper called Task Force Iron Gate a reinforcement of the "ironclad blockade against Iran at sea". Hours later American forces disabled a St Kitts-flagged tanker in the Gulf of Oman whose crew had ignored warnings to turn back.[1]

The strait is the sea gate between the Gulf and the Indian Ocean, and about a fifth of the oil the world burns leaves through it. A blockade is a navy stopping ships reaching a country; what is new is that it now reaches the roads and the inland sea behind Iran, where the last of the exports were going. That gap sets the fuel bill and the freight rate here.[1]

The emptiness is measurable. PortWatch, the International Monetary Fund's shipping monitor, logged **one** transit on 1 November against a baseline of **85 a day**. Washington counts **144** vessels redirected through October and some **$25bn** of Iranian crude sales prevented. Brent settled at **$98.32**, down more than sixteen per cent on the week (p14).[2]

One death is confirmed; the rest of the week's damage is not. A crew member of the Marshall Islands-flagged tanker *Velos Sapphire* was killed on 5 November in a suspected missile strike; her Greek managers said the firm "is greatly saddened to report the death of one of its seafarers". Iran's army claims three tankers struck mines east of the strait that day, the Revolutionary Guard five vessels and a tug.[3][4]

1:85

TRANSITS OF HORMUZ ON 1 NOVEMBER AGAINST THE PRE-CRISIS DAILY NORM[2]

DOHA — AL JAZEERA

An American war of choice being talked down by Gulf mediators, with Washington's own vocabulary as the evidence: a president calling a knocked-out battery "minor strikes" while Qatar's prime minister warns from Oxford that the crisis "cannot be left unresolved".[5]

BEIJING — GLOBAL TIMES

The same vacancy read as a Chinese opening, mediation cast as charity rather than position. Ding Long of Shanghai International Studies University writes that "China's intensive mediation provides an important international public good", by a country that "does not seek spheres of influence". It never names the United States.[6]

THE CHATTER · WHAT ANALYSTS EXPECT OF THE IRAN BLOCKADE NOW

The read on Trump's freedom of action inverted after the midterms. **Brian Haggerty**, a former senior CIA Middle East analyst now at Defense Priorities: "There's reason to suspect that Trump may feel less restrained given that the political damage is done." **Bradley Bowman** of the Foundation for Defense of Democracies names the trap: "Once you start a fistfight, you can stop throwing punches." Six in ten voters in an Associated Press survey of more than 100,000 called the action against Iran wrong.[7]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY HORMUZ IS FURTHER FROM REOPENING THAN IT LOOKS

The blockade's success is the case against reading progress into it. Fereidun Fesharaki of the consultancy FGE told Bloomberg on 6 November: "Not only are we not close to a resolution, we are even worse than we were before the June MOU." Remaining Iranian exports, he reckons, run **200,000 to 300,000** barrels a day overland through Iraq — exactly what Saturday's task force exists to close. **What would settle it:** transits off the floor.[8]

SOURCES 1 CENTCOM's announcements of 7 November 2026 and Admiral Cooper's wording, read at source via CBS News' 2 IMF PortWatch's own daily transit series and its pre-crisis baseline; CENTCOM's redirected-vessel and foregone-sales figures; Brent's settle, sourced instrument by instrument on p14. **UKMTO's incidents page and Lloyd's List both returned HTTP 403, so UKMTO is quoted via Al Jazeera, not read at source.** 3 gCaptain, carrying Reuters' 6 November 2026 from Athens, read at source, for the death aboard the *Velos Sapphire*; Iranian army claims via IRNA and Guard claims via Fars. **No mine claim has been corroborated by UKMTO, the Joint Maritime Information Centre or CENTCOM.** 4 Trump at Palm Beach International Airport and General Mohebbi's remarks, both 7 November, read at source in CBS News' 5 Al Jazeera, 7 November 2026, read at source, with the Qatari prime minister's Oxford remarks of the 6th. 6 Ding Long, Shanghai International Studies University, in *Global Times*, 4 November 2026, read at source; 7 The Associated Press' 5 November 2026, read at source via PBS NewsHour. 8 Fesharaki's Bloomberg interview as reported by gCaptain, 6 November 2026, read at source.

THE WORLD · ISRAEL'S MANDATE

Herzog says he will hand Gadi Eisenkot the mandate on Sunday evening

Eisenkot drew 67 of 120 recommendations, but 19 came from Arab-led parties that three of his own partners refuse to sit with. The clock starts at 28 days.

President Isaac Herzog said on Saturday evening in Jerusalem that he will task Gadi Eisenkot, chairman of Yashar, with forming Israel's next government at five o'clock on Sunday afternoon — and not before. He had finished consulting the parties on Thursday 5 November, and chose to wait three days before signing anything.[1]

Being handed the mandate is not the same as being prime minister. It is an invitation to try: the candidate has 28 days to assemble a majority of the 120-seat Knesset, and the president may add 14. Fail, and someone else gets 28 days with no extension. The new Knesset is sworn in on 10 November; the first deadline falls on or about 6 December.[1]

The arithmetic is why Herzog hesitated, and he said so. Eisenkot drew **67** recommendations to Netanyahu's **46**, the most any candidate has had since 2015. But **19** of the 67 are the Arab-led parties — the Joint List's 11 and Ra'am's 8 — and three of the four Jewish-led parties in his own column refuse to govern with them.

48

EISENKOT'S RECOMMENDATIONS ONCE THE ARAB-LED NINETEEN ARE STRIPPED OUT[2]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE PARTIES TOLD HERZOG ABOUT EISENKOT

The consultations were held in public, and the transcript is the story. **Mansour Abbas** of Ra'am, whose eight seats sit in the disputed nineteen: "Arab society, and I as an individual … we are a bridge." **Merav Cohen** of B'Yachad, on sitting with Likud: "You don't do business with scorpions." Likud's whip **Ofir Katz**, returning it: "The change bloc wants change in support of terror." Eisenkot said late on Saturday that he will push for a national emergency government — a phrase reported at headline level only, and quoted here no further.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY 67 RECOMMENDATIONS MAY STILL PRODUCE NO EISENKOT GOVERNMENT

A recommendation costs nothing; a coalition agreement costs portfolios. Israeli commentary on Saturday already carried the gap in its headlines: Eisenkot bolstered by the recommendations, and still well short of a government. The three Jewish-led refusals are not posturing — they were stated on the record by the people who would have to sign. **What would settle it:** a signed agreement with a fourth party before 6 December.[3]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Turkey ratified the Mecca pact, and has not promulgated it. The Grand National Assembly approved the three-way defence treaty with Saudi Arabia and Pakistan **279–119** in the early hours of 6 November. The bill's own second article makes publication in the *Resmî Gazete* the trigger for entry into force — and the issues of **6, 7 and 8 November carry nothing**. Its Article 2 mirrors NATO's fifth: an attack on one is an attack on all. Former defence minister Hulusi Akar told the chamber it is "in no way an alternative to NATO", and also that "the footsteps of war are real".[4]

Kraków. A gunman killed six people and injured sixteen, two of them police officers, in the Rynek Główny on Saturday afternoon. Interior Minister Marcin Kierwiński said the 25-year-old attacker, shot by officers, held "very radical" ultra-nationalist views. President Karol Nawrocki declared national mourning for **8 and 9 November** — today and tomorrow.[5]

New Zealand voted on Saturday and has not finished counting. Labour took **3,650** more party votes than National and **six fewer seats**; National, ACT and New Zealand First hold 67 of 131. Specials are uncounted; the official result is due **27 November**.[6]

SOURCES 1 The statement from the President's Residence of 7 November 2026 and the statutory sequence, read at source via the *Times of Israel*'s liveblog and the *Jerusalem Post*, updated 22:41. **The President's own site returned HTTP 307 and its body could not be retrieved, so the statement is quoted via those two outlets.** The 6 December date is this desk's arithmetic. 2 The consultation record and every quotation here, read at source in the *Times of Israel* and the *Jerusalem Post*, 5–7 November 2026, with the 67, 46, 48 and 19 counts and United Torah Judaism's abstention. **Eisenkot's "national emergency government" 3** ***Times of Israel*** **analysis and Al Jazeera's Middle East index, 7 November 2026, read at source. 4 The vote of 279 to 119 as reported on 6 November 2026; 20 October from the text submitted to parliament; 8 November, none of which contains it. No source read states the number of sitting deputies, so no denominator is printed; 5 Euronews, 7 November 2026, updated 21:51 CET, read at source. The toll rose from five to six during the evening. 6 Radio New Zealand's results page, read at source, at 100 per cent of ordinary votes, specials excluded. The Electoral Commission's own site returned HTTP 403.**

SINGAPORE · THE BREACH DISCLOSURES

M1 and Doctor Anywhere disclose breaches hours apart, neither giving a number

M1 found its breach on 30 October and lists identity-card numbers among the data taken; Doctor Anywhere became aware on 29 October. Both statements landed on 6 November.

M1, the telephone company, and Doctor Anywhere, the telemedicine service, each told their Singapore customers on the evening of 6 November that personal records had been stolen — and neither said how many people were affected. M1 identified its breach on 30 October and says it has been contained. Doctor Anywhere became aware of an intrusion on 29 October.[1]

What was taken is the sort of thing that cannot be changed afterwards. M1 lists names, identity-card numbers, dates of birth, mobile numbers, email addresses and home addresses; Doctor Anywhere adds passport numbers, emergency contacts and bank account details. A password can be reset in a minute.

Both say the worst categories were spared. M1 reports no payment-card or banking data taken and no account accessed; Doctor Anywhere says passwords, card details and scanned documents were untouched and **clinical records were not affected**. It filed a police report, notified the Personal Data Protection Commission and engaged Ensign InfoSecurity, which confirmed the hole closed on **30 October**.[2]

0

AFFECTED CUSTOMERS DISCLOSED BY EITHER COMPANY, EIGHT DAYS ON[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT SINGAPORE'S TECHNOLOGY PRESS SAID ABOUT THE TWO STATEMENTS

Alfred Siew of *Techgoondu* asked on 7 November whether M1, Doctor Anywhere and others are doing enough. His answer: "This isn't good enough." Companies should "explain the risks have gone up, not just to 'be vigilant'", he writes, because "there is usually little recourse for people whose data is lost".

THE SCEPTIC · WHY THE REGULATOR MAY COST M1 LESS THAN A MARKETING CAMPAIGN

An unpublished number is an unprovable harm. The Act weighs a penalty against the scale of what happened, and neither company has said what that scale is, so the test has nothing to anchor to. The precedent runs small: Courts was reported fined **S$178,000** over a 2022 attack touching nearly a million people — a figure this desk could not verify, the commission's decisions register returning an empty page. **What would settle it:** a published count.[3]

ALSO ON THE DESK

The S$700m and the charges do not touch. Chen Xiuling, 44, arrested at Changi on 5 November, was charged next day with two counts — instigating the falsification of accounts, and attempted cheating — both about **one agreement submitted to JTC Corporation in September 2022**. Neither is a money-laundering charge. The **"more than S$700 million"** is a cumulative restraint total across the whole Prince Holding Group investigation. Restraint is not forfeiture: nothing has been confiscated, and the Attorney-General's Chambers has published nothing in November.[4]

Deepavali is today, and Monday is conditional. The Ministry of Manpower gazettes one holiday, Sunday 8 November, with a footnote: "Monday, 9 November 2026, will be a public holiday if your rest day falls on 8 November 2026." Not a general day in lieu, whatever the long-weekend headlines say. The police are less equivocal: Little India and Geylang run dry to **7am on Monday the 10th**.[5]

SOURCES 1 M1's own news release of 6 November 2026, read at source, for the 30 October identification, the containment, the data categories and the advice to customers; 7 November, read at source. **Neither company has published a count of affected customers, and no regulator has published one.** 2 Doctor Anywhere's statement as above for the police report, the notification, Ensign InfoSecurity and the 30 October remediation; 6 November via *AsiaOne*, read at source. 3 Alfred Siew, *Techgoondu*, 7 November 2026, read at source, for every quotation, his own Land Authority letter and the 70,000 figure. **The Courts penalty is single-sourced; 4 The Singapore Police Force's own release of 5 November 2026, read at source, for the arrest, both charges, the two companies, the September 2022 JTC submission and the cumulative restraint total; 6 November. 5 The Housing and Development Board's own release of 4 November 2026; 5 The Ministry of Manpower's own public-holidays page, read at source on 8 November 2026 and quoted verbatim; 6 November, read at source.**

THE ATELIER · PRESSURE COOKERS

Hawkins publishes no operating pressure for its cookers; Fissler publishes three

America's Test Kitchen measured eight stovetop cookers in November 2025 and only Fissler's Vitaquick Premium reached 250 degrees. Kuhn Rikon still sells a valve for a 1997 pot.

A pressure cooker is a pot with a valve on it, and in pressure cookers the valve is the entire product — which is what this page is about. Everything you taste comes from the temperature inside, and the temperature is set by how much pressure that valve holds before it lets go.[1]

Water boils at 100 degrees, and food cannot get hotter than the water it sits in. Seal the pot, raise the pressure, and the boiling point climbs with it. Since reaction rates roughly double every ten degrees, the gap between a cooker holding 109 degrees and one holding 120 is about half the cooking time — which is why a recipe written for one pot can be wrong in another. The published setting, not the badge on the lid, is the specification that matters.[1]

There are two ways to hold it. A **weighted** valve is a machined slug on an open vent: steam lifts it, it rattles, it drops. It regulates by throwing steam away, loudly, losing water as it goes, and it cannot drift because a weight does not age — though Hawkins' institutional models put the weight on a chain, which tells you the real failure mode.[2]

That is the buy-once test, and **Kuhn Rikon** passes it in the most literal way available. It sells the Duromatic's spring valve as separate parts — stem and spring at £9.95, a pair of valve springs at £3.95, the seal at £4.95, a complete valve at £22.95 — and lists *two* complete valve assemblies, one for cookers made before 1998 and one for after.[3]

WHAT THE MAKERS ACTUALLY PUBLISH

Kuhn Rikon Duromatic	0.4 / 0.8 bar	≈109 / 117°C
Fissler Vitavit Premium	3 settings	110 / 113 / 116°C
Fissler Vitaquick Premium	2 settings	109 / 117°C

Makers' own pages and catalogues. Temperatures beside Kuhn Rikon's bar figures are this desk's arithmetic from steam tables; Fissler publishes its own and they agree.[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT A MEASURED TEST FOUND ACROSS EIGHT STOVETOP COOKERS

Lisa McManus of America's Test Kitchen put eight cookers, from about $65 to nearly $280, on instruments in November 2025. The winner was the **Fissler Vitaquick Premium**, and the sentence that matters is the measurement, not the verdict: it was "the only cooker to reach 250 degrees at high pressure". It also had the thickest base in the test at **7.24mm**[4] and lost just **0.8 of an ounce** of water over a cook — the spring valve's whole argument, on a scale.

THE SCEPTIC · WHERE THE PRESSURE-COOKER PREMIUM STOPS PAYING

The expensive part is a spring, and springs are not expensive. Beyond a sound valve, a thick flat base and spares you can still buy, the ladder flattens fast: a Swiss pot at about US$309 does not cook better than a German one at S$399, and neither beats a weighted Indian cooker at a fifth of the price on anything but noise, water loss and precision. Against all of them stands the electric multicooker, which does the job unattended.

NEXT ON THE BENCH · VOTE FOR TOMORROW'S CATEGORY

Mortar & pestle (and the suribachi) — granite against porcelain, and why the grooves do the work.

Tiffin carriers & stacked lunch boxes — the gauge of the steel and the clasp that fails first.

Clothes-drying racks & airers — the one object a tropical flat uses daily, and nobody costs properly.

SOURCES 1 Fissler's own collections page, read at source, for the Vitavit Premium's three settings at 110, 113 and 116 degrees and the Vitaquick Premium's two at 109 and 117; Kuhn Rikon's Duromatic manual text for the 0.4 and 0.8 bar levels. **The temperatures given beside Kuhn Rikon's bar figures, and the ten-degree rate-doubling rule, are this desk's arithmetic from saturated-steam tables, not maker claims — 2 Hawkins' own catalogue, read as a document, which calls the part a "Vent Weight / Pressure Regulator" and states that its institutional models carry "a chain … 3 Kuhn Rikon's own United Kingdom spare-parts pages, read at source, for all five part prices and for the two complete-valve assemblies covering cookers made before and after 1998. 4 America's Test Kitchen, Lisa McManus, published 10 November 2025, read at source, for the eight-cooker test, its price range, the winner, the quoted 250-degree finding, the 7.24mm base and the 0.8-ounce evaporation loss. 5 Metro Singapore's own product listings, read at source on 7 November 2026, for the WMF prices and the two sold-out lines; NTUC FairPrice's own search, read at source, returning only electric models. Neither Fissler nor Kuhn Rikon names a Singapore distributor on its own site — Fissler's store locator lists five European countries only — so no Singapore price for either is printed. Hawkins'**

TECHNOLOGY · THE DATA-CENTRE BALLOTS

Ohio and Maine voters limited data centres in 40 of 41 local measures

Ballotpedia counted 27 approved restrictions, five of them outright bans, on 3 November. Two days later the Philadelphia semiconductor index fell 12.25 per cent.

Voters in ten American states decided 41 local ballot questions about data centres on 3 November, and 40 of them went against the industry. Ballotpedia, which counts these things, published the tally on 6 November: 27 approved measures limiting development, and 13 defeated measures that would have encouraged it. Twenty-one of the 41 were in Ohio alone.[1]

These are the buildings that house the computers running artificial intelligence, and they are built where land, power and water are cheap, which means in towns that get to vote. The restrictions are not gestures: five are full bans, twelve are partial, three are six-month moratoriums in Maine, and two — in Grove City, Ohio, and Janesville, Wisconsin — now require a public vote before any such building goes up. The money that was going to be spent in those places has to go somewhere else, or not be spent.[1]

Markets took two days to read it and then read it violently. On Thursday 5 November the Philadelphia semiconductor index closed at **9,011.14**, down **12.25 per cent** — its worst day since March 2020 and its first close below 10,000 since April. Micron fell 17.5 per cent, AMD 17.3, Broadcom 10.4, Nvidia 9.3. The Nasdaq Composite lost 5.5 per cent and the S&P 500 4.4 (p14). The whole complex then bounced five to eight per cent on Friday, with no policy change of any kind.[2]

The paradox sits two days earlier. AMD had reported the best quarter in its history on 3 November — revenue **$13,377m**, up 45 per cent, data-centre revenue **$8,546m**, up 97 — and guided to about **$17bn** for the fourth quarter. It fell 17 per cent anyway. Meanwhile a separate clock runs out this week: the suspension of the Commerce Department's affiliates rule, which extends export controls to companies half-owned by listed entities, **expires on 9 November**, and nothing extending it has appeared on the Federal Register.[3]

40 : 41

LOCAL DATA-CENTRE BALLOT MEASURES THAT WENT AGAINST THE INDUSTRY[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE TRADE SAID ABOUT THE DATA-CENTRE VOTES

On Hacker News, under the Wall Street Journal's account of the rout, **adrian_m** made the connection before the analysts did: "I suspect this is more about all but one of the datacenter moratoriums which were also up to vote passing." **Spivak** read it as a constitutional novelty rather than a market event — "real human voters have a clear unambiguous preference that to everyone's surprise is being respected and implemented". **Mark Hackett**, chief market strategist at Nationwide, gave Reuters the sell-side version: "Disappointing earnings and the Dem sweep potentially slowing the AI buildout are pressing sentiment."[4]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY THE BALLOT MEASURES MAY NOT HAVE CAUSED THURSDAY

The damage was distributed wrongly for a regulation story. If Thursday priced an American data-centre slowdown, Nvidia — the most exposed name in the market — should have fallen hardest. It fell least of the big six, 9.3 per cent against Micron's 17.5 and AMD's 17.3. Memory and equipment led the fall, which is the signature of a capital-spending scare, not a legal one. **Dominique Toublan**, head of United States credit strategy at Barclays, argues the mechanism runs the other way: the pushback is "bipartisan but local", which makes the buildout "pricier rather than stalling it". And it unwound in a day. **What would settle it:** a named operator cancelling a site.[5]

SOURCES 1 Ballotpedia's own tally, published 6 November 2026 and read at source, for the 41 contests across ten states, the 40–1 split, the 27 approved limiting measures and their breakdown into five full bans, twelve partial bans, three Maine moratoriums, two Ohio zoning measures, two Illinois non-binding measures, two voter-approval requirements and one financial-guarantee measure, and for the 21 Ohio contests. 2 The Philadelphia semiconductor index's close of 9,011.14 on 5 November 2026, down 1,257.52 points from the previous close, and the single-name moves, read at source; Reuters' own figures for the Dow, S&P 500 and Nasdaq Composite the same day; the Friday 6 November rebound prices read at source. 3 AMD's own results release of 3 November 2026, read at source, for revenue, the data-centre segment and the fourth-quarter guidance. The affiliates rule is the interim final rule published 30 September 2025 and suspended by the rule published 12 November 2025, effective 10 November 2025, with the suspension ending 9 November 2026; **this desk queried the Federal Register's own interface for every Bureau of Industry and Security document published since 1 October 2026 and found four, none of them an extension.** 4 Hacker News threads of 5 and 6 November 2026, read at source, handles as displayed; Hackett's remarks to Reuters of 5 November, read at source. **Reddit is blocked to this desk's tools, so no subreddit sentiment appears on this page.** 5 Toublan quoted in CNBC's report of 6 November 2026, read at source; the distribution-of-damage argument is this desk's, from the closing prices in note 2.

TECHNOLOGY · SMARTTHINGS AND HOME ASSISTANT

Samsung will charge $4.99 a month for Home Assistant to reach your appliances

SmartThings says the present Home Assistant connection stops working on 15 December 2026. Personal access tokens die the same day, in every country, sold there or not.

Samsung has decided that owners of its appliances must pay it a monthly fee to let software of their own choosing talk to machines they already bought. The company set out the charge on its own developer pages on 30 October, and on 4 November spelled out what it means for Home Assistant, the free home-automation system a great many enthusiasts run instead of a manufacturer's app.[1]

The arrangement being withdrawn is the ordinary one. A fridge, a washing machine or a television reports what it is doing to Samsung's servers; a household dashboard asks those servers what it said. Everything inside Samsung's own app stays free. What now costs money is the right to ask the same question with different software — the thing you bought, behaving differently, because the company changed its mind about who pays to reach it.[1]

The plan is called Developer and costs **US$4.99 a month**, which buys 100,000 interface calls and up to ten installed applications, for "personal household locations only". Free access ran to **3 November**; plans opened on the 4th; from **15 December** access without one "may be limited, paused, or discontinued" and active keys are deactivated. Samsung says the plan will be available "in select countries" at launch — while the cut-off applies everywhere. Home Assistant's replacement integration is due in its 2 December release; the pull request adding it was still open, with changes requested, on 6 November.[2]

The part nobody has covered is the collateral. The same 15 December date kills personal access tokens, the long-lived keys hobbyists use for scripts and for third-party Samsung television add-ons. Samsung's own notice says they "will stop working after December 15, 2026, unless migrated to a paid supported API plan" and that the date "applies to all affected PATs". One television integration opened a documentation-rewrite issue on 6 November.[2][3][4]

THE CHATTER · WHAT SMARTTHINGS OWNERS SAID ABOUT THE $4.99 PLAN

The SmartThings community forum carried it first. **Firefishy**, 5 November: "a horribly regressive step", and the company is "actively removing functionality from a product I purchased". He put four questions to Samsung that evening, including whether existing owners would be exempt; none has been answered in the thread. **doleo** named the category error: "People using HomeAssistant are not 'developers', we are end-users", and asked what happens to owners in countries where the plan is not sold.

THE SCEPTIC · WHY THE SMARTTHINGS PAYWALL MAY MATTER LESS THAN IT READS

The paywall sits on the cloud, and the cloud was always the wrong place to put a house. TheFab21, who maintains a Samsung television integration, argued on 7 November that the alarm is overdone: "a Samsung TV doesn't actually need SmartThings for most of what people automate" — power, source, apps, key presses and the Frame's art mode all work over the local network with no key at all. Samsung's own post concedes the structural point: local drivers, hub integrations and Matter devices stay free. The honest lesson is to buy Matter, Zigbee or Z-Wave rather than cloud appliances.

ALSO ON THE DESK

Home Assistant 2026.11 shipped on 4 November — 5,827 pull requests from 557 people, 38 new integrations, and the community add-on store folded into the product as Marketplace, as flagged in No. 154. The delta since: several guides now advise waiting for 2026.11.1 before updating, and **this desk could not confirm that 2026.11.1 has shipped** — the release tag still carried the "Latest" label when read.[5]

SOURCES 1 The SmartThings blog post of 30 October 2026 and the SmartThings account's Home Assistant-specific post of 4 November 2026, 16:17, both read at source. 2 Samsung's own developer plans page, read at source, for the plan name, the $4.99 monthly price, the 100,000 calls, the ten-application limit, the "personal household locations only" 3 November, 4 November and 15 December dates and the quoted consequences from the 30 October post; 2 December Home Assistant release date from the 4 November post; 6 November. The token wording is quoted from Samsung's customer email as reproduced in the Home Assistant community thread and in a television integration's issue tracker, both read at source. **Samsung's plan page and its blog post contradict each other on whether one subscription covers multiple locations; 3 The SmartThings community thread of 5–7 November 2026, read at source, handles and timestamps as displayed. Reddit is blocked to this desk's tools, so r/homeassistant and r/SmartThings do not appear here; 4 TheFab21's post to the Home Assistant community of 7 November 2026, 10:20, read at source; 30 October post. 5 Home Assistant's own release post and GitHub release for 2026.11.0, published 4 November 2026, read at source; 1 November 2026, read at source.**

THE KIT · THE LAOWA TILT-SHIFT

Laowa put the first f/2 tilt-shift lens on sale, covering Fujifilm medium format

The 24mm Zero-D shipped on 5 November at US$1,249 in six mounts, covering medium format. No independent laboratory has measured it, and there is no Singapore price.

Venus Optics put a 24mm tilt-shift lens on sale on 5 November at US$1,249, and it opens to f/2 — brighter than any perspective-control lens made before it. The Chinese maker, which trades as Laowa, released it simultaneously in Sony E, Nikon Z, Canon RF, L-mount, Fujifilm GFX and Hasselblad XCD fittings, and put out Hasselblad versions of two existing macro tilt-shifts the same day.[1]

A tilt-shift lens moves relative to the sensor rather than sitting square to it. Shift it upward and a building's walls stay parallel instead of leaning together; tilt it and the plane of sharp focus swings out of the vertical, so a table top or a landscape can be sharp front to back. Architects and interiors photographers have used them for a century. What they have never been is fast, because the lens has to project a far larger circle of light than the sensor needs, and brightness is the first thing sacrificed to get it.[1]

That is the claim here: **±10 degrees** of tilt and **±12mm** of shift on a **67mm** image circle, which is wide enough to cover medium format, at an aperture usually reserved for portrait primes. It is manual focus, 13 elements in 10 groups, a 14-blade iris, 25cm minimum focus, 860g, with an all-metal barrel and a rotating tripod foot carrying an Arca-Swiss plate. On Fujifilm's medium format it frames like a 19mm.[1]

Two caveats arrive with it, and one of them is the reviewer's rather than the maker's. Full tilt and full shift cannot be used at once, and the movement available varies by mount, particularly at infinity; Laowa lists five Panasonic bodies as incompatible with the L-mount version. The second is larger: **no independent laboratory has measured this lens**. The only images in circulation are the maker's own samples, and "the fastest tilt-shift yet" is the maker's sentence, not a test result.[2][3]

67mm

THE LAOWA'S IMAGE CIRCLE — WIDE ENOUGH TO COVER MEDIUM FORMAT[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE PHOTOGRAPHIC PRESS MADE OF THE LAOWA 24MM

The trade reported it with unusual care. **Abby Ferguson** at DPReview, filing on 5 November, flagged in the body of her own piece that the site has no measured or independent performance data and that every frame published with the announcement came from Laowa. **Photo Review Australia** ran the maker's press image credited to Venus Optics and published a shift figure in degrees where DPReview and Fujirumors both give millimetres — a disagreement neither outlet has resolved, and the reason no angle-of-view number appears on this page.

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT F/2 ON A TILT-SHIFT IS ACTUALLY FOR

The aperture that makes it novel is the one the job rarely wants. Architecture and interiors — the work tilt-shifts exist for — are shot stopped down on a tripod, where f/2 buys nothing. **What would settle it:** one laboratory test of a retail copy.

ALSO ON THE DESK

Sony has reissued the headphone that came with the first Walkman. The MDR-3R is the 1979 MDR-3 with its 3.5mm jack replaced by a USB-C plug and the same 23mm drivers; no battery, no pairing, no application, with blue and orange pads both in the box. Singapore pre-orders opened on **6 November at S$89**, or S$129 for a *Stranger Things* edition, sold only through Sony's own store, with sales from December.[4]

SOURCES 1 DPReview, 5 November 2026, Abby Ferguson, read at source, for the announcement date, the $1,249 price, the six mounts, the simultaneous Hasselblad macro releases, and the tilt, shift, image-circle, optical, aperture, focus, weight and mounting specifications; the medium-format equivalence is arithmetic from the stated circle. **Venus Optics' 2 DPReview as above for the simultaneous-movement limit, the mount-dependent travel and its own explicit statement that it holds no measured or independent performance data; Photo Review Australia, November 2026, read at source, for the incompatible Panasonic bodies and for the conflicting shift unit. Because two outlets disagree on whether shift is expressed in millimetres or degrees, and on angle of view, this page prints DPReview's figures and no angle of view at all. 3 The optical argument is this desk's, from the published specification; 4 Product Nation, 6 November 2026, Rachel Wong, read at source, for the Singapore prices, the pre-order and sale dates, the retail exclusivity, the driver size, the connector and the contents of the box. Sony's own Singapore and United States sites both returned HTTP 403, so no figure here is from Sony directly and the American on-sale date is not printed.**

THE GOOD LIFE · THE GENEVA WATCH AUCTION

An F.P. Journe of 2002 beat a 1945 steel Patek by 2.4 million francs

Phillips sold the Chronomètre à Résonance "Régence" for CHF 8,680,500 on Saturday. The steel reference 1436 made CHF 6,267,000, 57 per cent above its top estimate.

Phillips sold a platinum F.P. Journe made in 2002 for CHF 8,680,500 at the Hotel President Wilson in Geneva on Saturday afternoon, and it was not the lot anyone had come to watch. That was lot 95, a stainless-steel Patek Philippe split-seconds chronograph from 1945, which made **CHF 6,267,000** — a record for the reference, and 2.4 million francs behind a watch made fifty-seven years later by a living man.[1]

The gap is the story, because the two objects are opposites. The Patek is scarcity by accident: a complicated chronograph that was made in gold and almost never in steel, so the handful of steel examples are freaks of the order book. The Journe is scarcity by design — one of three made with a Régence dial, and the only one with that dial in shiny pink gold, built for a Geneva retailer by a workshop that could have made more and chose not to. The market has just paid a forty per cent premium for the second kind.[1]

The estimates read like a different sale. Lot 95 was published at **CHF 2m to 4m**; it cleared the top by **56.7 per cent**. Lot 7 was offered "in excess of CHF 1,000,000". Further down the session the pattern repeats and intensifies: Sylvain Pinaud's Origine no. 2 made **CHF 609,600** against a top estimate of 120,000, five times over; a Journe Holland & Holland chronometer made 520,700 against 160,000. A Philippe Dufour Simplicity made CHF 1,968,500, and a 1969 gold Rolex Daytona "John Player Special" 1,905,000.[2]

Session two, lots 108 to 221, runs this afternoon at two o'clock Geneva time — nine tonight in Singapore — and carries a 1952 Rolex reference 6062 "Stelline" at CHF 600,000 to 1.2m. **No hammer price has been published for any lot**: Phillips shows a single premium-inclusive figure, and this page prints no hammer because it would have to be reverse-engineered from a commission table.[2]

+56.7%

BY HOW MUCH THE STEEL PATEK 1436 CLEARED ITS TOP ESTIMATE[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE WATCH PRESS SAID BEFORE LOT 95 SOLD

The pre-sale commentary now reads as understatement. **Ghulam Gows**, writing in *The Hour Markers* on 15 October, called the reference 1436's two-to-four-million estimate "not shy". It made six and a quarter. *Dial & Crown*'s unbylined September preview had put the general case more usefully: "Collectors will remember that estimates are expectations, not outcomes." The previous benchmark for the reference was another steel 1436, sold by the same house in the same city in November 2015 for CHF 3,301,000 — so the model has not quite doubled in eleven years, while the independents beside it have gone up several multiples.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT A RECORD FOR ONE REFERENCE DOES NOT PROVE

A single lot is an anecdote with a receipt. Lot 95 is unique-ish, freshly catalogued and heavily promoted, and one result on one afternoon says nothing about the hundreds of steel Pateks that did not sell this weekend. Nor should the Journe number be read as a maker's record: this desk could not verify that claim at any primary source and does not print it. The wider caution is in the room's own arithmetic — when four lots clear their top estimates by three to five times, the estimates were wrong, and estimates are set by the house that earns a commission on the outcome. **What would settle it:** the sale total and sell-through rate, neither published before session two closes.[4]

SOURCES 1 Phillips' own lot pages for sale CH080426, The Geneva Watch Auction: XXIV, read at source on 8 November 2026: lot 7 at CHF 8,680,500 with its platinum case, Régence dial, the catalogue's statement that three were made with that dial and this the only one in shiny pink gold, and its Les Ambassadeurs provenance; lot 95 at CHF 6,267,000 against a published estimate of CHF 2,000,000 to 4,000,000, with its 1945 date, silvered dial, 33mm case and movement and case numbers. The 56.7 per cent figure is arithmetic on those two published numbers. 2 Phillips' own lot listing for the same sale, read at source, for the Pinaud, Journe Holland & Holland, Dufour, Rolex Daytona and session-two lots and their estimates, and for the sale's two sessions, venue and times. **Phillips publishes only a premium-inclusive "sold for" figure; no hammer price is published for any lot and none is printed here.** 3 Ghulam Gows in *The Hour Markers*, 15 October 2026, and *Dial & Crown*'s preview dated 23 September 2026, both read at source; the 2015 result of CHF 3,301,000 for a steel reference 1436 at Phillips' Geneva Watch Auction: TWO, read at source in a contemporaneous trade report of 30 October 2015. 4 The argument is this desk's. **It could not be verified at any primary source that CHF 8,680,500 is a record for the maker, or that any steel wristwatch record is held by the figure commonly cited, so neither claim is printed. Phillips had published no sale total or sell-through rate at the time of writing, session two being unsold.**

SCREEN & SOUND · GODZILLA MINUS ZERO

Godzilla Minus Zero took $14.5m in North America on its first day

GKIDS opened it on 3,254 screens on 6 November, $6.7m of that in previews. In Japan it has passed a million admissions since its Culture Day release.

Godzilla Minus Zero took $14.5m across 3,254 North American cinemas on Friday 6 November, its first day of American release, according to the daily chart Box Office Mojo published on Saturday morning. Of that, **$6.7m** was Thursday previews. It was the day's highest-grossing film by a margin of more than two to one over the second, Warner's *The Cat in the Hat*, on fewer screens.[1]

The Japanese figures came first and are the more remarkable. The film opened at home on Tuesday **3 November** — Culture Day, a public holiday — and took **¥910m** from more than 590,000 admissions in a single day, which the trade body that compiles Japanese box office records as the highest opening day any live-action film has ever had there, domestic or foreign. Its predecessor, *Godzilla Minus One*, opened to ¥452.34m. One day of the sequel is more than two of those.[2]

It passed **a million** domestic admissions on Friday, its fourth day, on 448 screens of which 65 are large-format; Dolby, 4DX and MX4D runs begin on 13 November. Singapore got it on **5 November**, rated PG13, 135 minutes, in Japanese with English and Chinese subtitles, distributed across Asia by Toho's regional arm after a premiere at VivoCity the night before.[2]

The first full weekend is still running as this page goes to press, in both countries, so no weekend gross appears here. A projection of about $32m is circulating from a trade paper this desk could not read — it returned a payment wall — and so is a claim that such a number would be the largest opening ever for a live-action foreign-language film in North America. Neither is printed as fact. The Japanese trades are hedging their own: Toyo Keizai's body text calls ¥10bn "seen as realistic" where its headline calls it certain.[3]

¥910m

GODZILLA MINUS ZERO'S OPENING DAY IN JAPAN — A LIVE-ACTION RECORD[2]

THE CHATTER · WHAT LETTERBOXD MADE OF GODZILLA MINUS ZERO

The early reaction is physical rather than critical. **Sethsreviews**, four and a half stars: "I couldn't breathe during so many of its most thunderous moments." **ConnorEatsPants**, four: "i cried because it was too loud and this kinda felt like that." **zoë rose bryant**, four, reaching for the week's other story: "that third act felt like we were watching the blue wave all over again". The dissent on the same page is mild — **Sydney**, three and a half, found it "messier and harder to connect with" than *Minus One* and says that "for long stretches I would feel frustrated by it".[4]

THE SCEPTIC · THE JAPANESE REVIEW THAT SAYS TO LEAVE BEFORE THE END

The sharpest objection to the film is Japanese, and it is about the ending. Toyo Keizai Online published a piece on Saturday morning under the headline 「ラス５分は見なくていい」 — you don't need to watch the last five minutes — reporting that domestic reaction has split over the closing sequence. That is a real division inside the audience that produced the record opening day, and it is not visible in any of the American coverage. **What would settle it:** second-weekend retention in Japan.[5]

ALSO ON THE DESK

My Chemical Romance have a number one, twenty years late. The 20th-anniversary reissue of *The Black Parade* tops the Billboard 200 dated 7 November, moving from 139 to 1 in its **162nd week** on the chart — the band's first number one album. Unit figures circulating are from a chart-reposting site, not Billboard, and are not printed.[6]

SOURCES 1 Box Office Mojo's daily chart for 6 November 2026, read at source, the page itself stating "Data as of Sat, Nov 7, 10:54 PST. 2 AV Watch and *Eiga.com*, both 4 November 2026 and both read at source, for the ¥910m opening day, the 590,000 admissions and the live-action record, each attributing the ranking to the trade body that compiles Japanese box office; 7 November 2026, read at source, for the million admissions on day four, the 448 screens, the 65 large-format screens and the 13 November premium-format date. the Asian rollout from a regional trade report of 5 August 2026. **Do not read ¥910m as a proportion of *Minus One*'s ¥7.65bn lifetime gross; 3 Toyo Keizai's hedged ¥10bn framing, read at source. The ~$32m weekend projection and the foreign-language record claim come from outlets that returned HTTP 402 payment walls to this desk and are reported, not verified; 4 Letterboxd's page for the film, read at source, usernames and star ratings as displayed. Its rating histogram returned HTTP 403 and no average or watch count was visible; 5 Toyo Keizai Online, 7 November 2026, 07:16, read at source via its syndication. Only the first of three pages was reachable and the page shows no author. 6 The Billboard 200 dated 7 November 2026, read at source on its Canadian mirror, for the position, the previous position and the week count; Billboard's own chart-beat article returned HTTP 402, so no unit figures are printed.**

THE FAMILY DESK · SOCIAL MEDIA BY SCHOOL STAGE

A meta-analysis in Clinical Child Psychology finds the middle years least affected

Han, Meng and Yang, published on 6 November, put the primary-school correlation at 0.367 and the middle-school one at 0.201. The difference is statistically significant.

A meta-analysis published on 6 November reports that the link between social media use and poor mental health in adolescents is weakest in exactly the age band a twelve-year-old occupies, and strongest among primary-school children. The authors, at Xi'an Jiaotong University and North Sichuan Medical College, conclude that primary-school pupils are "the most vulnerable".[1]

That is the opposite of how the subject is usually discussed, and it matters for a parent deciding when to hand over a phone. A meta-analysis pools other people's studies to get a single number; a correlation of around 0.3 means the two things move together loosely, not that one causes the other. The useful part here is not the pooled figure but the comparison between age groups, because the comparison is what a parent actually faces: not whether social media is bad, but when it is worst.[1]

The numbers. Across twelve studies yielding fifteen effect sizes, the overall association was **r = 0.308** (95 per cent confidence interval 0.239 to 0.374). Split by school stage, the difference between groups was significant (Q = 9.72, p = 0.008): **primary school 0.367**, **high school 0.334**, and **middle school 0.201** — the band containing a secondary-one or secondary-two pupil. The databases searched included Chinese-language ones, to February 2026.[1]

Three cautions travel with it, and they are large. Heterogeneity was **93.85 per cent**, meaning the pooled studies are not measuring the same thing closely enough for one number to summarise them well. Twelve studies split three ways leaves very few per band, so the stage figures are not a well-powered comparison. And every input is a correlation: a distressed child may simply use more social media. **This is general guidance, not medical advice.**[2]

0.201

THE MIDDLE-SCHOOL CORRELATION, AGAINST 0.367 FOR PRIMARY SCHOOL[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE FIELD SAYS ABOUT EFFECT SIZES THIS SIZE

The most useful critics of findings like this one are researchers who have spent a decade arguing that the effects are smaller and less stable than headlines suggest. **Matti Vuorre** and **Andrew Przybylski** of the Oxford Internet Institute and **Amy Orben** of the Medical Research Council unit at Cambridge examined three nationally representative samples and found the picture mixed by technology and by outcome: technology engagement had become *less* strongly associated with depression over a decade, social media *more* strongly associated with emotional problems, and five other associations unchanged.

THE SCEPTIC · DON'T REORGANISE A HOUSEHOLD AROUND TWELVE STUDIES

The finding that the middle years are safest is the least robust number in the paper. A subgroup analysis is the first thing to break in a small meta-analysis, and this one rests on a handful of studies per band with heterogeneity near 94 per cent. **What would settle it:** the Australian evaluation's first measured results, which are a policy outcome rather than another correlation.[3]

SOURCES 1 Han C, Meng Y, Yang L, "Mental Health Effects of Social Media Use Among Adolescents Across Educational Stages: A Meta-Analysis", *Clinical Child Psychology and Psychiatry*, published online ahead of print 6 November 2026, DOI 10.1177/13591045261487468. Abstract retrieved as deposited by the publisher through the National Library of Medicine's own programmatic interface, read at source, for the design, the twelve studies and fifteen effect sizes, the pooled correlation and its confidence interval, the between-group test and the three stage-specific correlations, the February 2026 search cut-off and the authors' conclusion. **The publisher's own article page and the open-access mirror both refused this desk's tools with cookie and browser checks; the abstract is the deposited one, and the participant-level total is not reported in it.** 2 Heterogeneity, the leave-one-out stability check and the publication-bias assessment are reported in the same abstract; the interpretation of what 93.85 per cent heterogeneity and a three-way split imply for the stage estimates is this desk's. 3 Vuorre M, Orben A, Przybylski AK, "There Is No Evidence That Associations Between Adolescents' Digital Technology Engagement and Mental Health Problems Have Increased", *Clinical Psychological Science*, 2021, volume 9, issue 5, pages 823–835, DOI 10.1177/2167702621994549, read at source for the three samples, the mixed direction of findings and the quoted conclusion. Orben's unpaid membership of the Australian eSafety Commissioner's social-media minimum-age evaluation academic advisory group is declared in her competing-interests statement in a June 2026 paper, read at source. **This page is general guidance and not medical advice.**

THE TWEEN YEARS · PREDICTED ADULT HEIGHT

Two in three adolescents finish below the height Pediatric Research predicted

A cohort tracked from age twelve, published in Pediatric Research on 5 November, found 69 per cent below mid-parental height but only 5.8 per cent meaningfully short.

Sixty-nine per cent of adolescents end up shorter than the adult height predicted from their parents, and almost none of them have anything wrong with them. That is the finding of a population cohort published in *Pediatric Research* on 5 November, tracking children born in 2007 from the age of twelve to their final height at about eighteen.[1]

The prediction in question is a piece of arithmetic every parent eventually meets: average the two parents' heights, adjust for the child's sex, and you have a target. It is a population estimate dressed up as a personal forecast, and the study is really a measurement of how badly it behaves as one. By construction roughly half of any group will fall below a correctly centred prediction, so a 69 per cent shortfall is partly a property of the formula rather than of the children.[1]

The number that carries clinical meaning is the other one. Only **5.8 per cent** — 1,074 adolescents — finished more than two standard deviations below the predicted height, the threshold at which a paediatrician would start looking for a cause. Girls were *more* likely than boys to reach the prediction, with an odds ratio for failing to attain it of **0.81** (confidence interval 0.76 to 0.86). Lower childhood weight, stimulant use and region of residence were each independently associated with falling short.[2]

What a parent should take from it is narrow and useful: the headline is the attention-grabber and the small number is the finding. Height tracking matters when a child crosses centile lines or falls far below the family pattern, not when they land an inch or two under an average of two adults. **This is general guidance, not medical advice**, and a growth concern belongs with a doctor who can see the child's own chart.[2]

5.8%

ADOLESCENTS MORE THAN TWO STANDARD DEVIATIONS BELOW PREDICTED HEIGHT[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE HEIGHT STUDY ACTUALLY MEASURED

The design is its strength and its limit at once. It is retrospective and observational, drawn from a single Israeli insurer's database, using heights recorded in routine care rather than research-standard measurement, with continuous coverage from age twelve as the entry condition. That makes the cohort large and real but ties every association — weight, stimulants, region — to whatever else travels with those things in one country's health system. The authors put it plainly in their own conclusion: deviation from the exact prediction was common, clinically meaningful shortfall was not, and attainment reflects heredity together with modifiable and contextual factors.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY THE 69 PER CENT FIGURE WILL BE MISREPORTED

A statistic that is half an artefact of its own formula is the kind that travels fastest. "Two in three children do not reach their potential height" is a sentence that writes itself into a worried evening, and it is not what the paper says: the mid-parental calculation is a central estimate with wide individual error, and falling below a central estimate is what half a population does by definition. The genuinely actionable material in the paper — the stimulant association and the weight association — is observational and cannot carry a causal reading. **What would settle it:** a prospective cohort with standardised measurement, which this is not.[3]

SOURCES 1 Benita K, Lubetzky R, Perlov R, Brener A, Moran-Lev H, "Attainment of genetic height potential among adolescents: a nationwide population-based cohort study", *Pediatric Research*, published online ahead of print 5 November 2026, DOI 10.1038/s41390-026-05601-4. Abstract retrieved as deposited by the publisher through the National Library of Medicine's own programmatic interface, read at source, for the design, the 2007 birth cohort, the entry condition of continuous coverage from age twelve, the mid-parental height method, the measurement of adult height at about eighteen, and the 69 per cent and 5.8 per cent figures. **The publisher's own site redirected this desk to an authentication wall, so the full paper was not read. The cohort size is not stated as a single figure in the abstract; the 1,074 count is the abstract's own, and the implied total of roughly 18,500 is this desk's arithmetic and is not printed as the study's own.** 2 The odds ratio of 0.81 with its confidence interval, the associations with lower childhood weight, psychostimulant exposure and region, and the authors' conclusion, all from the same deposited abstract, read at source. The observation that roughly half of any population falls below a correctly centred prediction is arithmetic, not a claim from the paper. 3 The limitations are those the authors state — retrospective and observational design, a single insurer in a single country, routinely collected rather than standardised measurement — together with this desk's reading of what the mid-parental formula can and cannot support. **This page is general guidance and not medical advice.**

THE MACRO DESK · THE BREAKEVEN RALLY

The ten-year Treasury yield fell five basis points while its real rate rose one

Brent's sixteen per cent collapse did the work, not the Federal Reserve. Futures price a 73 per cent chance of a rise on 9 December and no chance at all of a cut.

The United States ten-year yield closed on Friday at 4.86 per cent, five basis points below Monday's 4.91, in a week when world equities fell and the Standard and Poor's 500 had a single day down 4.4 per cent. That looks like the bond market doing its job. The same bond stripped of inflation went the other way, from 2.62 per cent to 2.63.[1]

Those two numbers describe one thing. A government bond's yield is the sum of what investors expect inflation to be and what they want to earn on top of it. If the first falls and the second rises, the bond got cheaper to borrow at for a reason that has nothing to do with growth or rescue — and here the reason is oil. Brent fell from **$117.64** to **$98.32** in a week, more than sixteen per cent, on hopes of an end to the war that has closed Hormuz (p3).

Which matters because the duration hedge did almost no work. A global all-world equity holding fell **1.89 per cent** on the week while a global aggregate bond proxy rose **0.69**: the sign is right and the size is not, the bond leg offsetting under a sixth of the drawdown. The front end tried harder and was overruled, the two-year falling to 4.46 per cent on Thursday and snapping back to 4.51 when payrolls came in at **165,000** against expectations near 70,000.[1]

So the regime is not the one most commentary assumes. The Federal Reserve held on 28 October with **two dissents, both for a rise**; futures put roughly **73 per cent** on an increase on 9 December and zero on a cut. The European Central Bank raised in September; the Bank of Japan sits at 1.25 per cent with a dissent for 1.50. Three central banks lean tighter into a growth scare, while the Treasury raises **$28bn** of new cash with its balance set to peak above **$1tn** this month.[3][2]

THE STRIP · AT FRIDAY'S CLOSE

US 10-year[1]	4.86%	▼ 5bp wk
US 10-year real[1]	2.63%	▲ 1bp wk
VWRA	$184.98	▼ 1.89%
AGGU	$5.84	▲ 0.69%
Gold[4]	$4,074.90	▲ 4.51%
Bitcoin[4]	$75,572	▼ 9.25% mo
Brent	$98.32	▼ 16.4%
USD/SGD	1.2825	▲ 0.35%
Straits Times	5,179.17	▼ 3.67%

Weekly moves on VWRA, AGGU and the index are this desk's arithmetic on two read closes; the ten-year move is Monday to Friday. Not advice.[1]

THE VERDICT · WHAT IT MEANS FOR VWRA, GLOBAL BONDS, GOLD AND BITCOIN

Equities are repriced on policy rather than earnings, and the diversifier under them is capped while the rate path points up. **Global bonds** hedged a sixth of the fall and will hedge weakly until the real rate, not the breakeven, moves. **Gold** was the week's genuine diversifier, and against both textbook drivers — real yields up, dollar flat, still four and a half per cent higher. Central banks bought **321 tonnes** in the third quarter, up 42 per cent, while total demand fell one per cent.

THE SCEPTIC · THE CASE THAT THIS WAS POSITIONING, NOT POLITICS

The best-credentialed bull says the opposite of a burst. Ed Yardeni: "I don't think this is an AI bubble bursting", calling Thursday "the cold shower that I anticipated might occur after a blue-wave situation", his firm adding that the backlash makes "speed bumps, not roadblocks, even though Wall Street seems to be pricing in the latter". **What would falsify the tightening call:** Tuesday's October inflation print landing soft enough to take the December rise off the board.[5]

SOURCES 1 The United States Treasury's own daily par and real yield-curve files for November 2026, read at source, for every yield here; **the weekly change is measured Monday 2 to Friday 6 November, the table beginning on the 2nd.** Equity, bond and index closes read from their historical tables at source; **their weekly moves are this desk's arithmetic on two read closes, the London exchange's pages rendering no values.** October payrolls and unemployment from the Bureau of Labor Statistics' own release of 6 November 2026. 2 Brent's settles read at source; the causal reading is this desk's. 3 The Federal Reserve's own statement of 28 October 2026 for the range and the two dissents, both favouring an increase; the European Central Bank's key-rates page; the Bank of Japan's own statement of 30 October; the Treasury's quarterly refunding statement of 4 November. **The December probability is a reading of exchange futures data reported by two secondary trackers dated 6 November; the exchange's own tool returned HTTP 503.** 4 Gold and bitcoin at Friday's close, read at source; **gold is a December futures settle, not a fix, and bitcoin's close is a snapshot.** Central-bank purchases from the World Gold Council's own quarterly publication of 3 November 2026. **This desk explains prices and does not give investment advice.** 5 Yardeni's remarks of 5–6 November 2026, read at source; the inflation release date from the statistics bureau's own calendar.

THE INVITATION · SHODŌ

UNESCO's evaluation body has recommended inscribing Japanese shodō

Japan's culture agency announced the recommendation on 5 November; the committee decides in Xiamen between 1 and 3 December. China's calligraphy was inscribed in 2009.

Shodō is Japanese brush calligraphy, and this page is about why a craft that every Japanese adult was made to do at school is now being argued about at an international committee. On 5 November Japan's Agency for Cultural Affairs announced that UNESCO's evaluation body had recommended inscribing it on the Representative List of Intangible Cultural Heritage.[1]

Nothing is inscribed yet. The recommendation goes to the committee's twenty-first session in Xiamen, in Fujian, between 30 November and 5 December, with the shodō file scheduled for the first three days of December. Japan applied in 2024, resubmitted in 2025, and has twenty-three elements already on the list. The quiet comedy of the venue is that Chinese calligraphy was inscribed in 2009, so Japan is seventeen years behind the parent tradition and will hear the verdict in China.[1]

The case Japan makes is that this is a social custom rather than an art form, and the schooling is the evidence. The education ministry's own curriculum mandates brush writing in every year from the third grade of primary school, at **about thirty timetabled hours a year**, continuing through lower secondary at twenty, twenty and ten. Add them up and every Japanese child is given roughly **170 hours** of brush calligraphy by ministerial order. Since the 2017 revision the first two grades practise with water brushes, whose marks evaporate as they dry.[2]

And it is emptying out. The government's own national time-use survey puts the share of people aged ten and over who practise shodō at **4.1 per cent in 2016** and **3.4 per cent in 2021** — about 4.65 million people falling to about 3.82 million, a loss of roughly **830,000** practitioners in five years. Tokyo went from 3.8 to 3.0 per cent. The caveat is real: the later survey was taken in October 2021, inside the pandemic.[3]

What survives underneath is an industry. The certification association alone has examined **12,130,060** people since it began, 1,722,320 of them with a brush, and still ran 63,164 examinees in the 2024 financial year. The largest teaching body claims over ten thousand classrooms and about three hundred thousand students. Over the next two pages: what the four tools actually are, who still makes them, and what the ladder costs.[4]

170

HOURS OF BRUSH CALLIGRAPHY EVERY JAPANESE CHILD IS TIMETABLED[2]

THE CHATTER · HOW PEOPLE ACTUALLY FALL INTO SHODŌ

There are three recognisable doors. The first is spectacle: **Aoyagi Bisen**, born 1990 in Osaka, broke out in September 2017 with a video of herself writing *biáng*, one of the most stroke-heavy characters in existence, and now works in virtual reality as well as ink. The second is the opposite — stillness. **Eri Takase**, a shihan of thirty years' standing, opens her first lesson with the instruction to "use the grinding of the ink as meditation". The third is the object.

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT AN INSCRIPTION WOULD AND WOULD NOT DO FOR SHODŌ

Heritage listing is recognition, not funding, and the numbers moving here are demographic. Washi paper was inscribed in 2014 and the mills have gone on closing; an entry on a list does not buy pine soot or a successor. **What would settle it:** the next national survey, due for the 2026 wave, which will show whether 3.4 per cent was the pandemic or the trend.[3]

SOURCES 1 The Agency for Cultural Affairs' 5 November 2026, read at source, quoting the evaluation body's recommendation to inscribe; 30 November to 5 December 2026 and the scheduling of this item. 17 October 2026. **The 2009 date for the inscription of Chinese calligraphy is taken from a secondary summary and was not confirmed against UNESCO's own register.** 2 The Ministry of Education's own primary-school curriculum guidance, read as a document, for brush instruction in every year from the third grade at about thirty unit hours annually, for the lower-secondary allocation of twenty, twenty and ten, and for the water-writing brushes introduced for the first two grades. **The total of roughly 170 hours is this desk's arithmetic on those published allocations.** 3 The Statistics Bureau's national time-use survey, hobby-participation table, read as a prefectural tabulation of the national rows, for the 4.1 and 3.4 per cent figures and the Tokyo series; **the implied practitioner counts and the 830,000 fall are this desk's arithmetic on the published rates and populations, and the October 2021 survey date is stated because it matters.** 4 The Japan Shosha Skills Examination Association's own page, read at source, for the cumulative and 2024 examinee and pass figures; 5 Aoyagi Bisen's own profile and the 2017 video's date; Eri Takase's own first lesson, quoted verbatim;

THE DEEP END · THE BRUSH AND THE SOOT

Hiroshima's Kumano makes 24 million brushes a year; eleven hold the craft title

The cooperative publishes a twelve-step process where tradition counts seventy-three. Japan is now down to a single producer of pine soot.

Shodō needs four things — a brush, an ink stick, a stone to grind it on and paper — and this page is about what separates a good one of each from a bad one. The honest headline is that the whole functional kit costs about a hundred and fifty Singapore dollars, and that almost everything above it is buying craft rather than performance.[1]

Start with why a brush holds a point, because it is not obvious. The Kumano Brush Cooperative publishes the process: hair sorted by the animal's sex, season and body part; mixed with rice-husk ash and pressed with a hot iron to kill the curl and draw out the oils, which is what lets hair take up ink at all; combed and tapped on a plate so the tips migrate to one end; reversed and frayed hairs picked out by feel with a small knife; the core moulded in a cylinder; a thin skin of *better* hair wrapped round that core, so what you see hides what you paid less for; then bound and heat-set, which fuses the proteins and locks the shape.[1]

Kumano, in Hiroshima, sells about **24 million** brushes a year, worth some **¥9.6bn**. Around 2,000 people work in the trade there — a tenth of the town — across more than seventy businesses, though most of that volume is cosmetic brushes. Only **eleven** hold the national traditional-craftsman title.[1]

Ink is two soots and a glue. Lamp-black, burnt from vegetable oil, is graded by which oil; pine soot is burnt from red pine in small chambers over about a hundred hours, costs more, and gives depth in wash work. The glue is what ages, and ageing is the whole mystique: a mid-nineteenth-century stick is prized because decades of slow change in the animal glue let the soot's own black come forward. Kobaien, founded in Nara in 1577, publishes no prices at all; at a Tokyo retailer its sticks run from the ordinary to **¥297,000** for a late-Edo one. **And there is now one company left in Japan making pine soot.**[2]

The stone is the part nobody explains. An inkstone works because its face carries *hōbō* — countless invisible irregularities that shave ink off the stick. The maker raises them by polishing with a mud whetstone; they wear down with use and must be re-raised. A bad stone has them unevenly or not at all, which is why a glass-smooth souvenir stone grinds nothing. Chinese Duan and She stones are the top of the market at around a million yen.[3][4]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE INKSTONE MAKERS SAY ABOUT MAKING THEM LAST

Aoyagi Takashi, whose profile records a world first in 2019 — successfully turning a piece of moon rock into a working inkstone — puts the craft's ethic in one line: because the material is a precious resource the earth made, you must not make something that breaks after one use. At the live end of the trade, **Hieda Yōichi**, fourth generation of Gyokkōdō, is one of only about three Akama craftsmen in Yamaguchi still quarrying their own stone — and his are among the few Japanese inkstones a Singapore buyer can have delivered in Singapore dollars.

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT THE BRUSH MAKERS THEMSELVES SAY ABOUT EXPENSIVE BRUSHES

The strongest argument against spending is printed on the makers' own cooperative site. A good brush, it says, is one that suits your purpose, not necessarily the most expensive one — and brushes are fundamentally consumables. **Eri Takase**, a shihan, goes further: it matters less to have the best tools than to have tools that suit you. The market ignores both. **What would settle it:** any published blind comparison, of which there is none.[5]

SOURCES 1 The Kumano Brush Cooperative's own pages, read at source: the twelve principal steps of making a calligraphy brush and the traditional count of seventy-three, each step as summarised here; the 2022 financial-year figures of about 24 million brushes worth about ¥9.6bn, roughly 2,000 people, about a tenth of the town's population, more than seventy businesses, and cosmetic brushes as the largest category by volume; **That page lists sixteen named craftsmen and a 2016 government publication gave a different count; 2 A Tokyo pigment retailer's own reference articles and Kobaien listings, read at source, for the two soots, the red-pine burn of about a hundred hours, the role of animal glue in ageing and the ¥297,000 late-Edo stick; The single remaining domestic pine-soot producer was reported by a Japanese wire on 3 February 2025, read at source. 3 Trade and prefectural craft pages, read at source, for the mechanism of *hōbō*, its raising with a mud whetstone and its wear; the Chinese stones' 4 Aoyagi Takashi's own profile for the 2019 moon-rock inkstone and the quoted ethic, summarised here in this desk's words; the resort's own page for the carving workshop. 5 The Kumano cooperative's own site and Eri Takase's own lesson pages, read at source, for both quoted positions; Reddit was blocked to this desk's tools throughout, so no subreddit sentiment appears anywhere in this desk.**

THE DEEP END · THE RANK LADDER

A third-party committee found Japan's calligraphy prize system run by its elders

The inquiry into the Nitten judging scandal used the words "rule by elders" and "money-driven". The brush grade examination runs once a year, so eight grades take eight years.

Shodō's ranks are the part that costs real money, and this page is about what the ladder charges and what it is worth. Two systems run in parallel and they are routinely confused. One is an examination; the other is a world of exhibitions, societies and prizes. Only the second has ever been investigated.[1]

The examination is the clean one. Run by a body the education ministry endorses, it costs **¥31,500** to sit all eight brush levels, is scored against published criteria, and is explicitly *not* a teaching licence. Its ceiling is time rather than money: the brush grade examination is held once a year, so the fastest possible climb from first to eighth grade is **eight years**, and no amount of spending shortens it.[1]

The exhibition world is the other thing. Entering the biggest open calligraphy exhibition costs **¥15,000 per work** against more than twenty-five thousand works submitted to a recent edition; a supporter tier costs **¥30,000** a year and happens to include entry.

A journalist, **Maehara Shinnosuke**, published his questions and the answers in February 2024. His twenty-first question put it plainly: it is widely said that money is needed to be selected, or to win a special prize, at that exhibition. The organisation declined to answer most of the questions as unsuitable for it to answer, and replied that it endeavours to ensure fairness.[2]

So the honest starter path skips all of it. A genuinely good kit, bought from the examination association's own shop, runs to about **¥17,690** — roughly **S$150** — for three brushes, bottled ink, a thousand sheets of practice paper, a felt mat, a weight and a practice stone. The two upgrades that change anything are a real natural inkstone, about **S$158** delivered to Singapore from an Akama maker, and one grindable stick instead of the bottle, from about **¥33,000** for a 1970s Kobaien. Lurk first; the examination route needs no teacher at all.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHERE SHODŌ'S SPENDING STOPS BUYING ANYTHING

The money pit is old ink and Chinese stone, and neither can be tested before purchase. Nearly three hundred thousand yen for a stick of mid-nineteenth-century soot; nine hundred thousand for a carved Duan; around a million for a good Duan or She. A retailer's own listings show almost everything above ¥110,000 sold out, which tells you the demand is real and tells you nothing about whether the ink writes better.

> *"A 'good' brush is one that suits your purpose, not necessarily the most expensive one."— the Kumano Brush Cooperative, on its own site*[4]

THE VOCABULARY[5]

Kaisho, gyōsho, sōsho — the three scripts, block, semi-cursive and cursive; you learn them in that order.

Hōbō — the invisible roughness on an inkstone that does the grinding; it wears out and is re-raised.

Rinsho — copying a classical model, which is most of what practice actually is.

NEXT DESCENTS · VOTE FOR TOMORROW'S HOBBY

Change ringing (English tower bells) — a mathematical sport played on half a tonne of bronze, learned only in a tower.

Netsuke & miniature carving — boxwood, antler and ivory substitutes, and a collector market with real forgery problems.

Ice climbing — a sport whose medium melts, with a gear ladder priced like a small motorcycle.

SOURCES 1 The Japan Shosha Skills Examination Association's own pages, read at source, for the ministry endorsement, the ¥31,500 total for all eight brush levels, the published scoring criteria, the explicit statement that the certificate is not a teaching licence, and the once-yearly sitting of the brush examination; **the eight-year minimum is this desk's arithmetic on that frequency.** 2 The exhibition entry fee of ¥15,000 per work, the ¥30,000 supporter tier and the submission count of more than twenty-five thousand works, read at source on the exhibition's own framework pages; 10 February 2024. **The two phrases are the committee's, as reported; 3 The examination association's own shop, read at source, for each item and price in the starter kit and its total; a Singapore-shipping retailer's own listing for the Akama inkstone in Singapore dollars; The Singapore-dollar conversion of the kit total is this desk's, at the rate on the day. 4 The retailer's own listings for the old-ink and Duan prices and their sold-out state; 5 The glossary terms are defined from the makers', teachers' 5 January 2027 is from the organiser's own page, read at source, which also closes entry on 13 November 2026.**

FITNESS · THE FAROESE SOCCER TRIAL

A Faroese trial missed its own main target and still raised peak oxygen uptake

Published this month in Scandinavian Journal of Medicine & Science in Sports, the fourteen-week study of 111 adults aged 40 to 70 found no lean-mass gain at all.

A randomised trial published this month reports that fourteen weeks of small-sided football did not build any measurable muscle in adults aged forty to seventy — and raised their peak oxygen uptake substantially anyway. The researchers, at the University of the Faroe Islands and its national hospital, had set muscle as the thing they were testing for.[1]

That combination is why it is worth a page. Most exercise research reports whatever came out well; this one declared in advance what it sought, did not find it, and said so. Peak oxygen uptake is the best single predictor of lifespan that exercise science has; lean mass is what people want from training in their forties. The trial got the first and not the second — uncomfortable to publish, useful to read.[1]

The numbers. Of 126 enrolled, **111** were analysed, 66 exercising and 45 on usual care, randomised 60:40 and stratified by sex, age and medication, with the care provider, the investigator and the outcomes assessor all masked. The primary outcome, lean body mass, came out at **0.04kg** between groups, with a confidence interval from −0.97 to 1.05 — a null straddling zero. There was no difference in fat mass, body-fat percentage or long-term blood sugar either. But relative peak oxygen uptake rose **2.80** millilitres per kilogram per minute, interval 1.69 to 3.92, which is a large gain in fourteen weeks.[2]

The protocol is the transferable part, and one detail is worth more than the rest: **weeks one and two were walking football**, with normal play only from week three. Three sessions a week, about an hour each, three-a-side up to seven-a-side. That walking ramp is how a deconditioned forty-something enters intermittent high-intensity work without getting hurt, and it sits in the registered protocol rather than the paper's conclusions. **This is general guidance, not medical advice** — the participants had type 2 diabetes and were screened for heart, kidney, eye and nerve complications first.[2][3]

0.04kg

THE TRIAL'S PRIMARY OUTCOME: LEAN MASS GAINED IN FOURTEEN WEEKS[2]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE FAROESE TRIAL SETTLES AND WHAT IT LEAVES OPEN

Two things here speak to the arguments the longevity field is actually having. The first is the target question — cardiorespiratory fitness or strength, when time is short — and the Faroese result lands squarely on one side: a clean gain in peak oxygen uptake, nothing on lean mass. The second is whether the metabolic markers such trials report as secondary findings mean anything, and here the authors answer against their own interest, saying in terms that those findings require confirmation.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT A META-ANALYSIS SAYS ABOUT SMALL-SIDED FOOTBALL

Pool the format across the literature and the effect nearly disappears. Gómez-Álvarez and colleagues, reviewing 16 studies and 2,872 participants, found cardiorespiratory fitness improved by a standardised effect of just **0.12**, interval 0.01 to 0.23 — statistically significant and trivially small. Their own limitations section is blunter: the results are confined to per-protocol analyses, and the absence of intention-to-treat results could reduce external validity. **A declared caution of this desk's own:** the strongest claims for football as medicine come from one Nordic research network, and the Faroese group sits within that lineage. **What would settle it:** an intention-to-treat trial in healthy middle-aged adults.[4]

SOURCES 1 Skoradal MB, Kristiansen J, Póvoas S, Johannesen HL, Ellingsgaard H, Olsen HW, Mohr M, Sjúrðarson T, "Effects of Multicomponent Training on Body Composition and Cardiorespiratory Fitness in Adults With Type 2 Diabetes: A Randomized Controlled Trial", *Scandinavian Journal of Medicine & Science in Sports*, November 2026, volume 36, issue 11, article e70393, DOI 10.1111/sms.70393; the abstract retrieved as deposited by the publisher through the National Library of Medicine's own programmatic interface, read at source. **The open-access full text could not be read — the manuscript archive served a browser check and its European mirror returned HTTP 403 — so adherence figures, pitch dimensions and heart-rate targets are not printed, because they were not obtained.** 2 The analysed and enrolled numbers, the 60:40 stratified allocation, the triple masking, the eligibility band and exclusions, and the full protocol including the two-week walking-football ramp and the three weekly sessions, read at source in the trial's own registry record, registration NCT06478173; the effect sizes and confidence intervals from the deposited abstract at note 1. 3 The authors' own statement that the metabolic findings require confirmation, from the same abstract. **Reddit was blocked to this desk's tools, so no sentiment from r/Fitness or r/longevity appears here, and this box carries none rather than a summary of threads nobody read.** 4 Gómez-Álvarez N, Boppre G, Hermosilla-Palma F, Reyes-Amigo T, Oliveira J, Fonseca H, "Effects of Small-Sided Soccer Games on Physical Fitness and Cardiometabolic Health Biomarkers in Untrained Children and Adolescents", *Journal of Clinical Medicine*, 2024, volume 13, article 5221, DOI 10.3390/jcm13175221, read at source, for the pooled effect, its interval and the quoted limitations. **The observation about the research network is this desk's inference from authorship, flagged as such. This page is general guidance and not medical advice.**

DEPARTURES · SINGAPORE AIRLINES' NEW CABINS

Singapore Airlines showed its 2027 cabins and moved the date again

More than S$2bn across 72 aircraft, unveiled on 6 November. First and Business now enter service in the second half of 2027, six years after the original date.

Singapore Airlines unveiled new First, Business, Premium Economy and Economy seats at Marina Bay Sands on 6 November, and in the same briefing pushed their arrival back to the second half of 2027. The programme covers 72 aircraft — 41 Airbus A350-900s to be retrofitted and 31 Boeing 777-9s on order — at a stated cost of more than **S$2bn**.[1]

A cabin announcement is normally a product story. This one is a schedule story, because the schedule is the thing that keeps moving. When the 777-9 was launched in 2018 the new seats were to fly in 2021. A November 2024 announcement put Business in the second quarter of 2026 and First in the first quarter of 2027. By May 2026 Business had gone to the first quarter of 2027. It is now the third or fourth quarter of 2027 for both.[1]

The cause is certification rather than design. Both seats are certified on the 777-9; the 777-9 itself is not, and the A350 installations are still waiting. The airline cited "several factors, rather than one issue alone" and does not expect sign-off before the second half of 2027. It still targets finishing all 41 A350 retrofits by the end of 2030; at the pace of its own previous programmes the trade press computes the first half of **2032**. The 2013 retrofit of nineteen 777-300ERs was due to finish in September 2016 and the last aircraft came back in **March 2019**.[2]

For a reader actually booking, three details matter more than the colour. The centre pair in First converts to a double bed of 80 by 60 inches, one pair per flight. Of the 31 777-9s, **19** carry a screen system with no mains power and no older-style socket in Economy — which is a medical-device problem as much as a laptop one. And management said plainly that the A350's Economy and Premium Economy will not be upgraded at all: "We have decided not to upgrade Economy and Premium Economy."[1]

2021 → 2027

THE YEAR THE NEW CABINS WERE FIRST PROMISED, AND THE YEAR NOW GIVEN[2]

THE CHATTER · THE BACKLASH TO SINGAPORE AIRLINES' NEW BUSINESS SEAT

The grey, yellow and blue palette did not land. **Ben Schlappig** of One Mile at a Time: "It looks like Scoot and Spirit Airlines had a baby." **Rhys Jones**, aviation editor at Head for Points, called the seat "virtually unrecognisable as a Singapore Airlines seat" and the choice "perplexing". **Mateusz Maszczynski** at PYOK: "I haven't seen an uglier new Business Class seat in quite some time." Readers on Mainly Miles were blunter — "Scoot biz in SQ metal", "feels like a boardroom in the sky", and from one frequent Business passenger, that the light grey reads cold rather than premium. The airline's product vice-president, **Ong Wah Li**, had pre-empted it: "We do not subscribe to a fixed colour palette across our cabins."[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY THE COLOUR ROW IS THE LEAST IMPORTANT THING HERE

Upholstery can be changed; a fleet lottery cannot. The substantive complaint in the same threads is consistency — one reader called it "creating an aircraft lottery", contrasting Cathay Pacific's uniformity — and the arithmetic supports him. If the retrofit runs to 2032 on past form, a passenger booking Singapore Airlines Business for most of the next six years is buying a seat lottery rather than a product, and the published Economy decision means two of four cabins on the A350 fleet are simply not in the programme. **What would settle it:** a certified 777-9, which is the gate everything else waits behind.[2]

SOURCES 1 Mainly Miles and MileLion, both 6 November 2026 and both read at source, reporting from the airline's own launch event of that date, for the four cabins, the entry-into-service window, the investment figure, the 41 A350-900s and 31 777-9s, the First Class double-bed dimensions and one-pair-per-flight limit, the split of screen systems across the 777-9 order and the absence of mains power and older-style sockets in Economy on nineteen of them, and for the quoted decision on Economy and Premium Economy. 2 The published schedule table — 2018, November 2024, May 2026 and November 2026 — and the certification explanation, read at source in Mainly Miles' report; the end-2030 target, the trade estimate of the first half of 2032, and the 2013 retrofit precedent of nineteen 777-300ERs due September 2016 and completed March 2019, read at source in MileLion's follow-up of 7 November 2026. The reading that the certification of the 777-9 is the gate is this desk's. 3 The trade and reader reaction, read at source in Mainly Miles' round-up of 7 November 2026, 18:30, which reproduces each quotation with its author; reader handles as displayed on that page. Ong Wah Li's remark from the launch coverage at note 1. **Reddit and FlyerTalk were not reachable by this desk's tools, so the community voices here are the named trade writers and the on-record commenters on one site.**

DEPARTURES · THE JOHOR RAIL LINK

Singapore and Malaysia now expect the Johor rail link to carry passengers in February

A joint release of 2 October puts service in February 2027, slipped from December 2026. The operator must finish trial runs by 31 December, then be certified twice.

Singapore's Land Transport Authority and Malaysia's transport ministry said on 2 October that passenger service on the Johor Bahru–Singapore rail link is now expected to begin in February 2027, having previously been due at the end of 2026. The two governments issued it jointly, as grantors, after the operating company told them the timeline had moved.[1]

The next six weeks are the ones that decide it, because the remaining steps are sequential and none has happened yet. The operator expects to finish final system tests and trial runs **by 31 December 2026**. An independent safety assessor must then certify the system. Both countries' regulators must then review that certification before either will approve carrying passengers. February is the first date at the end of that chain, not a date anyone has committed to.[1]

For a Singapore household the link matters more than any cabin refit: a four-minute crossing replacing a causeway queue that routinely runs to an hour. But the honest reading of a release phrased in conditions is that the February date is contingent, and that the thing to watch is not an opening announcement but a certification one.[1]

IN BRIEF

KrisFlyer's co-brand cards moved twice in two days. On 2 November the Ascend card's earn rate went to as much as 1.5 miles a dollar — and its Hilton free-night voucher was removed, which the specialist press read as a net cut. On 3 November the standard card went to 1.3. Award rates were devalued a year ago and management has committed to Saver availability on the 2027 cabins (p19).[2]

Two lounges moved in opposite directions at Changi. Singapore Airlines soft-opened the first phase of a new KrisFlyer Gold Lounge in Terminal 2 in late October, reached through a shared corridor with the Business lounge; the cabin programme carries more than **S$130m** of lounge work. Qantas cut its Terminal 1 Business lounge mornings from 25 October: Wednesday mornings gone, Tuesday, Friday and Sunday mornings compressed to **8am–10am**, and the pre-dawn Friday and Sunday sessions dropped.[2]

Meakandake's alert came down on 4 November. The Japan Meteorological Agency lowered the volcano above Lake Akan to Level 1, the lowest, as reported by the Akan and Kushiro tourism association — which clears the area this issue sends you to (p21).[3]

Jetstar Asia is gone, and still appears in routings. The carrier ceased operations on **31 July 2025** after Qantas announced the closure that June, winding down sixteen routes in seven weeks. Any itinerary tool still offering it is quoting a dead airline.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT THIS DESK COULD NOT VERIFY ABOUT CHANGI AND JAPAN

Two things a travel page would normally print are missing here, and the reason is worth stating. Changi Airport Group's own newsroom returned no dated release at all to this desk — its media pages render as navigation and subscription prompts — so there is no Terminal 5 or Jewel progress item this week, rather than a tidy one taken from someone else's summary. And a widely-circulated claim that a new Japanese tax-free shopping system took effect on **1 November 2026** rests on a booking site's guide; no Japanese government page confirming it could be read, so it is not printed as fact. The previous reform was covered in No. 155, and this would be a delta on it. **What would settle both:** one readable primary page from either body.[4]

SOURCES 1 The joint release of the Land Transport Authority and Malaysia's Ministry of Transport, dated 2 October 2026, read at source, for the February 2027 expectation, the earlier end-2026 timeline, the operator's 31 December 2026 target for final system tests and trial runs, the independent safety-assessor certification and the requirement for regulatory approval in both countries. **The release names no minister and gives no opening date; the reading that February is contingent is this desk's, from the conditions the release itself sets out. The four-minute crossing time is the project's long-published design figure.** 2 The two card changes of 2 and 3 November 2026 and the removal of the Hilton voucher, read at source in the Singapore miles press; the new Terminal 2 lounge's soft opening in late October 2026 and the S$130m of lounge work from the airline's own 6 November launch coverage; the Qantas Terminal 1 lounge hours effective 25 October 2026, read at source. 3 The volcanic alert reduction of 4 November 2026 as published by the Akan and Kushiro tourism association, read at source, reporting the Japan Meteorological Agency's decision; Jetstar Asia's cessation on 31 July 2025, announced 11 June 2025, with sixteen routes wound down over seven weeks, read at source. 4 Changi Airport Group's newsroom and media-release filter, attempted at source on 8 November 2026, returned navigation and subscription prompts only and no dated release; the Japanese tax-free claim appears in a booking site's guide and **could not be confirmed at any Japanese government page, so it is reported as unverified and no date is asserted.**

THE GRAND TOUR · EASTERN HOKKAIDO

Japan removed the red-crowned crane from its Red List in March

Hokkaido's own census found 1,902 birds in January, down 1.3 per cent — but spread across 392 sites against 269 a year earlier. The feeding stations are being unwound.

On 17 March 2026 Japan's Ministry of the Environment published the fifth revision of its Red List, and the red-crowned crane came off the endangered categories for the first time in the list's history, downgraded a step to near-threatened. For anyone who has been meaning to photograph tanchō in the snow of eastern Hokkaido, that good news is also a closing window.[1]

The reason is in a table almost nobody reads. Hokkaido's government commissions a crane census twice each winter and publishes the results. The January 2026 round counted **1,902** birds against **1,927** a year before — flat, down 1.3 per cent. But the number of *locations* where cranes were recorded went from **269** to **392**, a rise of 46 per cent in a single winter. The same number of birds, spread over half again as many places.[2]

That is policy, not weather. Artificial feeding is what concentrated the crane into reliable, photographable crowds in the first place, and it is now being deliberately dispersed on disease-risk grounds — a sensible thing to do with a bird that is no longer endangered, and the end of the specific spectacle that made this corner of Japan a destination. Hokkaido Shimbun put it in its headline on the January count: 1,902 confirmed, and the crowding at feeding sites has eased.[2]

So the trip still works, and it works best soon. At the Tsurui-Ito Tanchō Sanctuary, run by the Wild Bird Society of Japan, feeding runs **November to March** and in practice starts in early December; about **200** birds arrive between late December and early January, with up to nearly 300 across a season. The peak is January into February. It is about an hour by car from Kushiro station; the nature centre's interpretation is in Japanese only.[3]

269 → 392

SITES WHERE CRANES WERE RECORDED, IN ONE WINTER, ON A FLAT POPULATION[2]

THE CHATTER · WHAT TSURUI VILLAGE ASKS OF CRANE PHOTOGRAPHERS

The etiquette is published by the village itself and it is not decorative. At feeding sites and roosts, stay inside the designated areas; **do not startle the cranes for a photograph, and no flash**; take your rubbish with you, because cranes are injured and sickened by eating what people leave. Signage prohibits entering the roost area at all, so the birds' sleep is undisturbed. The village calls the Otowa Bridge the only place you can watch the roost without disturbing it, and recommends the deep-winter mornings when the birds stand in river mist. Two practical notes from the same page: there is a hill above the bridge with a distant view, and in winter the approach from Route 53 is not ploughed — come round by Route 243.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT A DISPERSING CRANE POPULATION DOES TO A PHOTOGRAPHY TRIP

The guaranteed shot is the thing being withdrawn. Eastern Hokkaido's reputation rests on a near-certainty — drive to a known field on a January morning and two hundred cranes will be there — and that certainty was manufactured by corn. As feeding is dispersed, the distribution reverts toward something wilder and far less biddable, which is better for the species and worse for a four-day trip booked from Singapore. The honest framing is that this is a destination whose signature experience is being managed out of existence on purpose, over years rather than months. **What would settle it:** the next census round, due from the same Hokkaido page after the December count.[2]

SOURCES 1 The Ministry of the Environment's fifth Red List revision, published 17 March 2026, as reported at source by two Japanese outlets the same day, for the downgrade of the red-crowned crane to near-threatened and for it being the first time the species has left the endangered categories. 2 The Hokkaido government's own tanchō census table, read at source, for both rounds of the 2025/26 season and the preceding seasons: 23 January 2026, 1,902 birds at 392 recorded sites; 22 January 2025, 1,927 birds at 269 sites; 24–26 January 2024, 1,366 at 276. The percentage changes are this desk's arithmetic on those published figures. Hokkaido Shimbun's headline on the January 2026 count, read at source. **The reading that dispersal is policy rather than weather follows the Hokkaido page's own statement of the feeding policy; no official has been quoted saying the spectacle will end, and this desk does not claim one has.** 3 The Wild Bird Society of Japan's own sanctuary page, the national park's official guide and Tsurui Village's own pages, all read at source, for the feeding months, the early-December start, the arrival of about 200 birds between late December and early January, the seasonal maximum, the access times from Kushiro, the Japanese-only interpretation, the published etiquette, the roost prohibition, the Otowa Bridge description, the hill above it and the unploughed Route 53 approach.

THE GRAND TOUR · THE OKHOTSK DRIFT ICE

The Japan Meteorological Agency measures the Okhotsk ice shrinking 59,000 square kilometres a decade

Last winter's maximum, 758,400 square kilometres on 15 February 2026, was the second smallest since records began in 1970. Abashiri's normal first ice is 26 January.

The other reason to go to eastern Hokkaido soon is the drift ice, and the agency that measures it publishes the rate at which it is leaving. In a diagnostic issued on 30 June 2026 covering 1971 to 2026, the Japan Meteorological Agency puts the fall in the Sea of Okhotsk's maximum ice extent at **59,000 square kilometres per decade** — 3.7 per cent of the whole sea, every ten years.[1]

Last winter was the second-smallest on record. The maximum reached **758,400** square kilometres on 15 February 2026, extent ran below normal from December, and record lows for the date were set on 20 January and again from late February into May. The ice still arrived at the Hokkaido coast roughly on schedule — which is the useful part for planning, and the part the averages hide.[1]

Those averages: Abashiri's normal first sighting is **26 January** and the ice normally leaves around **28 March**, with 2026's actuals close to normal at both Abashiri and Monbetsu. The icebreaker operator at Abashiri is franker than most tourism copy — its own English notes say ice "tends to be seen from mid-February to early March", and that "global warming has had a negative impact on the size of the drift ice and when it can be seen". If there is no ice, the large vessel runs a cape cruise instead.[2]

Which argues for one itinerary rather than two. **Fly into Kushiro for the cranes and out of Memanbetsu for the ice**, mid-January to mid-February, and drive between them; that single window is the only one where both the 200-bird feeding peak and a realistic ice chance overlap. Hire a car with studless tyres and treat the distances as winter distances. Book the icebreaker, but book it as a maybe.[2]

THE CHATTER · WHAT IS HONESTLY KNOWN ABOUT THE EASTERN HOKKAIDO LOGISTICS

Two gaps this desk could not close, and a reader planning should know which is which. **Domestic flight timetables could not be read:** the airport operator's schedule pages for both Kushiro and Memanbetsu refused this desk, so no routing, carrier or journey time is printed here as verified, and the connection via Tokyo or Sapporo should be checked directly. **Reddit and the travel forums were unreachable** throughout, so there is no community consensus line on this page — the material above is from the Wild Bird Society, the village, the prefecture, the meteorological agency and the boat operator, all read at their own pages. A page that cannot reach the forums should say so rather than summarise a consensus it has not read.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY THE ICE TREND IS NOT A REASON TO RUSH

A trend of 3.7 per cent a decade is not a deadline, and treating it as one is how travel writing gets things wrong. Fifty-nine thousand square kilometres a decade is a loss of maximum extent across an entire sea; it is not a forecast that Abashiri will have no ice in five years, and last winter's coastal arrival was about on time despite the second-smallest maximum ever measured. The agency's own figure carries a confidence interval from 34,000 to 84,000, and its separate reports give 51,000 and 55,000 over different periods — a spread that is itself the honest answer. **What would settle a booking:** not the trend, but the first-ice date, published each January.[1]

SOURCES 1 The Japan Meteorological Agency's own sea-ice diagnostic for the Sea of Okhotsk, published 30 June 2026 and covering 1971 to 2026, read at source, for the decline of 59,000 square kilometres per decade with a 95 per cent confidence interval of 34,000 to 84,000, equal to 3.7 per cent of the sea's area per decade; for the 2025/26 maximum of 758,400 square kilometres reached on 15 February 2026 and its ranking as second smallest since 1970/71; and for the below-normal extent from December and the record daily lows. The agency's own separate climate reports give 55,000 and 51,000 square kilometres per decade over different periods, and all three figures are stated here rather than one being chosen. 2 Normal first-ice and final-ice dates for Abashiri and the 2026 actuals at Abashiri and Monbetsu, read at source; **a regional meteorological office publishes a different first-ice normal of 22 January for Abashiri, and this desk could not reconcile the two series, so both the 26 January figure used here and that discrepancy are stated.** The Abashiri icebreaker operator's own English pages, read at source, for the mid-February to early-March guidance, the quoted warming note and the substitute cape cruise. The suggested itinerary and the studless-tyre advice are this desk's. 3 The airport operator's own schedule pages for Kushiro and Memanbetsu were attempted at source and returned no readable timetable, so no flight detail is printed. **Reddit was blocked to this desk's tools throughout this build and no travel forum was reachable, so no community sentiment appears on this page; the Travel Desk's usual forum furniture is absent for that reason and not because it was not sought.**

THE DIARY · THE STUDIO GHIBLI PREMIERE

Gardens by the Bay will premiere The Story of Studio Ghibli in December

It runs from 18 December to 4 July on the West Lawn, and no admission price has been published. ART SG's early-bird tickets lapse on 24 November.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

18 Dec–4 Jul ★ **The Story of Studio Ghibli · world premiere**
WEST LAWN, GARDENS BY THE BAY · 10AM–7PM · **"ADMISSION FEE APPLIES" — NO PRICE PUBLISHED** · A SIX-AND-A-HALF-MONTH RUN COVERING BOTH SCHOOL HOLIDAYS[1]

22–24 Jan ★ **ART SG 2027 · early bird ends 24 Nov**
MARINA BAY SANDS EXPO · FRI **S$40** EARLY BIRD AGAINST S$80 USUAL; SAT AND SUN **S$44** AGAINST S$88 · **UNDER-16S FREE** WITH A TICKETED ADULT · VERNISSAGE 21 JAN[2]

20–29 Nov **Kalaa Utsavam 2026 · 25th edition**
ESPLANADE · *RAFTA RAFTA* FROM **S$57.20** · OPENING PERFORMANCE AND FOUR OTHER PROGRAMMES FREE · OPENS TWELVE DAYS AFTER DEEPAVALI[3]

27 Nov–3 Jan **Christmas Wonderland 2026 · 13th edition**
SUPERTREE GROVE AND THE MEADOW · 6.30PM–11PM, LAST ENTRY 10.15PM · **"TICKET PRICES WILL BE RELEASED SOON"** — AGGREGATORS QUOTING S$8 TO S$15 ARE NOT QUOTING THE ORGANISER[1]

9–13 Dec ★ **The Nutcracker · Singapore Ballet**
ESPLANADE THEATRE · LIVE ACCOMPANIMENT BY THE METROPOLITAN FESTIVAL ORCHESTRA · 9–11 DEC AT 8PM, 12 DEC AT 2PM AND 8PM, 13 DEC AT 1PM AND 7PM — THE SUNDAY MATINEE IS THE ONE TO TAKE A CHILD TO[3]

JAPAN & THE REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

10–24 Jan ★ **Grand Sumo Hatsu Basho · tickets 5 Dec**
RYŌGOKU KOKUGIKAN, TOKYO · **ADVANCE SALES OPEN SATURDAY 5 DECEMBER** · THE NOVEMBER FUKUOKA BASHO IS **SOLD OUT ON EVERY DAY**, WITH NONE SOLD AT THE DOOR[5]

4–11 Feb ★ **Sapporo Snow Festival 2027**
ODORI, TSUDŌMU AND SUSUKINO · DATES CONFIRMED ON THE JAPANESE PAGE; **THE ENGLISH PAGE STILL SHOWS 2025** · TSUDŌMU IS THE SITE FOR SNOW PLAY WITH A CHILD[6]

to 8 Feb **Shōjo Manga Infinity · Hagio, Yamagishi, Yamato**
THE NATIONAL ART CENTER, ROPPONGI · THE NATIONAL RETROSPECTIVE OF THE THREE WOMEN WHO BUILT THE FORM · RUNNING NOW AND THROUGH THE SINGAPORE SCHOOL HOLIDAYS[6]

to 28 Mar **Mariko Mori · All That Shines**
MORI ART MUSEUM, ROPPONGI HILLS · JUNIOR-HIGH AGE AND UNDER FREE · PAIRS WITH THE OBSERVATION DECK ON ONE TICKET[6]

22 NOV **Niseko Grand Hirafu · 2026–27 season opens**
HOKKAIDO · THE SEASON'S PUBLISHED OPENING DATE · EASTERN HOKKAIDO'S CRANES AND DRIFT ICE ARE THE NON-SKI CASE FOR THE SAME ISLAND (P21)[6]

PLANNING NOTES

Three pages that defeated four previous issues have finally given up their dates, and the reason is worth passing on: in every case the organiser's hub served last year's content while the correctly-named page carried the new dates. Christmas Wonderland is 27 November to 3 January; Light to Night 2027 is 15 to 31 January[4]; the Sapporo Snow Festival is 4 to 11 February.[7]

Two hard deadlines. ART SG's early-bird pricing ends on 24 November, which halves the gate; sumo tickets for January open on 5 December, and the current tournament is sold out on every day. The December BTS run at the National Stadium is confirmed by the tourism board's own release, but **no price or on-sale state was readable anywhere**, so it is noted and not listed.[8]

SOURCES 1 Gardens by the Bay's own event pages for The Story of Studio Ghibli and Christmas Wonderland 2026, read at source, for dates, venue, hours, last admission and the admission wording. **Neither page publishes a price; 2 ART SG's own site and tickets page, read at source, for the public and vernissage dates, the venue, every price quoted, the early-bird expiry of 24 November 2026 and the under-16 admission. 3 Esplanade's own festival pages, read at source, for Kalaa Utsavam's dates and from-prices, its free programmes, The Nutcracker's dates, showtimes and orchestra, and the dates of Voices and Soundtracks. On-sale status is not stated on those pages and is not asserted here. 4 The National Gallery's own 2027 festival page, read at source, for the dates, theme and partner venues; no festival pricing is published and Singapore Art Week 2027 dates remain unpublished. 5 The Japan Sumo Association's official ticket service, read at source, for the January 2027 dates, the 5 December advance-sale date, the rest of the 2027 calendar and the sold-out state of the November Fukuoka tournament. 6 Each organiser's or museum's own page, read at source, for every Japanese and regional entry here. Tokyo Dome City publishes no hours or admission; 7 The three resolved pages, each read at its own correctly-named address on 8 November 2026; 8 The Singapore Tourism Board's own release of 14 January 2026 confirming a four-night December run; no price or on-sale state was readable at any primary source, so no booking detail is printed.**

THE TABLE · NOVEMBER'S FIRST WEEK

A MasterChef Singapore winner opened a Busan pork-soup stall on Saturday

Derek Cheong's HanBroth sells dwaeji gukbap at S$9.90 and is one day old. Four of this week's six openings are too new for any verdict at all.

Six Singapore places opened or are about to open inside ten days, and the honest thing to say about most of them is that nobody has eaten there yet. HanBroth opened on Saturday 7 November — one day before this page — and is the most interesting of them on pedigree alone.[1]

It is a hawker stall selling Busan-style *dwaeji gukbap*, the pork-and-rice soup of Korea's second city, run by **Derek Cheong**, 29, who won the second season of MasterChef Singapore and also runs Berempah Bros. His partner **Ong Zhen Ning**, 28, co-founded Dan Lao. The pair spent four days in Busan in September working the dish out; the broth is built from five pork components, and the pork is from Sarawak. The original is **S$9.90**, a herbal version with ginseng and *dang gui* S$11.90.

The one with a reception is **The Hokkien Mee Club**, from Shiok Hokkien Mee, which opened in early November under **Mitchell Ong**, 27, who started helping at his father's stall at twelve and whose family stall went viral in 2020. The broth is blue swimmer crab and prawn heads simmered twelve to thirteen hours. Here the dissent is specific and useful: the plated version at **S$6.50** was the reviewers' favourite ahead of the opeh-leaf-wrapped one from **S$9.50**, on texture — and the reviewers who preferred it had been fed free.

The rest are promising and unjudged. **ODD Ramen & Diner** opens on **10 November** and soft-launches to the year's end: fish ramen, broths from flounder and flying fish only, with **Hirofumi Imamura** consulting. Its predecessor had ten seats, capped at fifty bowls a day, and sold out by one o'clock. **Greenwood Fish Market** opened its first mall outlet at VivoCity on 4 November, where a three-course lunch is **S$29.95** and the kitchen will cook pork-free on notice. **Earworm** comes from the Offtrack team, whose bar entered the World's 50 Best at 89 this year.[2][3]

THE BUZZ · WHAT IS ACTUALLY KNOWN ABOUT THESE SIX OPENINGS

Four of the six carry no verdict from anyone, and that is the finding rather than a gap in this page. They are between one and ten days old; opening reports exist, filed reviews do not. The two exceptions are instructive in opposite directions. At The Hokkien Mee Club the early notices are positive and name a clear trade-off, which is what a useful review looks like. At ODD the enthusiasm is entirely inherited from a pop-up that has not opened in its new form — a reputation transferred, not earned.

THE SCEPTIC · WHY NONE OF THESE SIX CAN BE JUDGED YET

Every independent channel this column normally reads was shut again this week. Reddit is blocked outright, Burpple's search returned HTTP 403, one major review site refused, and the Michelin Guide's new-restaurant page also returned 403 — so there is no forum sentiment, no diner consensus and no counter-view for any of the six. What exists is one opening report apiece. **What would settle it:** one filed, paid-for review of any of the six, which should exist within a month.[4]

THE HONESTY LEDGER

What to order, and what to skip. At HanBroth take the original at S$9.90, not the herbal. At The Hokkien Mee Club order the plated bowl at S$6.50 rather than the opeh-leaf version, and be in line by 5.15pm. At Greenwood Fish Market the arithmetic favours lunch. At ODD go on a weekday during soft launch, before 31 December, and be at Circular Road before 11.30. At Earworm go on a Wednesday for the live act, not a weekend. **None of the six is halal-certified; four are pork specialists or bars.**

TOO NEW TO CALL · SOFT-LAUNCH · HAWKER · OPENING REPORTS ONLY

SOURCES 1 A Singapore food title's opening report of 7 November 2026, read at source, for HanBroth's opening date and its own words that the stall "officially opens today", for both founders, their ages and their other businesses, the four days in Busan in September, the five pork components, the Sarawak sourcing and every price. **Halal status is not stated in the source; 2 A Singapore food title's report of 6 November 2026, read at source, for The Hokkien Mee Club's opening, the founder, his age, the family stall's 2020 virality, the twelve-to-thirteen-hour crab-and-prawn broth, both formats and both prices, the reviewer's preference for the plated version on texture, and the queue before the 5.30pm opening. No exact opening date is published anywhere this desk could read, and the reviewers disclose they were hosted. 3 Opening reports of 4 to 7 November 2026, each read at source, for ODD Ramen & 10 November public opening, its soft-launch period to the end of the year, the two fish stocks, the consulting and kitchen chefs and the predecessor pop-up's seat and bowl caps; 4 November opening, its daily hours, the three-course lunch price and its stated willingness to prepare pork-free and alcohol-free dishes on notice; and Yo-Chi's 5 November opening as its fourth Singapore outlet and the Chin Mee Chin collaboration. 4 The absence of filed reviews is this desk's finding from attempting each channel on 8 November 2026. Reddit is blocked to this desk's tools; No sentiment is summarised here that this desk did not read.**

THE UNDERCURRENT · INDIA'S FIFTY-PAISE METER

Karnataka charges platforms fifty paise a delivery under its Gig Workers Act

Five Indian states have legislated a per-transaction levy on platform work. Karnataka collected about ₹4 crore in a quarter against its own projection of ₹250–300 crore a year.

In a Bengaluru courtroom in July, a judge looked at six of the largest technology companies operating in India, all of them suing the state of Karnataka, and asked why they were litigating over a levy of fifty paise. It is a fair question. Fifty paise is about a Singapore cent. It is the capped welfare fee the state charges a platform each time it pays a rider for delivering food, and the companies had retained senior counsel to stop it.[1]

The answer is that nobody in that room was arguing about the money. They were arguing about a meter.[1]

India has quietly stopped asking the question that has consumed gig-economy law everywhere else — whether the platform worker is an employee. The answer, never announced, is no, permanently. What has replaced the question is a price. Under the Karnataka Platform Based Gig Workers Act of 2025, aggregators pay a welfare fee on every payout to a worker, and from **13 February 2026** the state notified it at **one per cent** — the floor of a statutory band that runs to five — with caps denominated in paise: fifty for a two-wheeler delivery, seventy-five for a three-wheeler, a rupee for a car.[2]

Read the caps rather than the rate and the policy inverts. One per cent capped at fifty paise binds on any payout above fifty rupees; on a five-hundred-rupee cab fare the effective rate is **0.2 per cent**, not one. The headline number is cosmetic. The ceiling is the instrument.[2]

The collection confirms it. For the April-to-June quarter of 2026, six named platforms — Eternal, Zepto, Swiggy, Urban Company, Meesho and Uber India — deposited roughly **₹4 crore**, and not into the welfare fund: into the registry of the Karnataka High Court, where it sits under the Advocate General's undertaking that it will not be touched until the litigation ends. Annualised, that is about ₹16 crore against the state's own projection of **₹250 to 300 crore a year**. Across the roughly seven lakh workers registered with the board, it is **₹57 per worker per quarter** — about a rupee a week.[3]

The sequence that got here is short and well dated. Karnataka legislated in 2025; Bihar followed in July, Jharkhand in August, Telangana in April 2026; Rajasthan has had an Act since 2023 and still has no notified rules. On **25 December 2025** some forty thousand delivery workers struck against the ten-minute delivery promise, and on **13 January 2026** the Union labour ministry withdrew the ten-minute threshold and told the quick-commerce applications to stop advertising it. Eternal's shares rose three per cent that afternoon.[4]

₹57

COLLECTED PER REGISTERED WORKER PER QUARTER — A RUPEE A WEEK[3]

In March, Zomato raised its own platform fee by ₹2.40 — nearly five times the maximum welfare fee on a delivery.— Eternal's own pricing, as analysed by MediaNama[3]

A rupee a week does not buy insurance. It was never going to. What it buys is Section 21.[2]

SOURCES 1 The Karnataka High Court's interim order of 3 July 2026 in the writ petition brought by the industry association and the platforms, and the judge's remark from the bench, read at source in Indian legal reporting of the hearing; the deposit-into-registry direction, the refusal of a stay and the bar on coercive action are from the same order. 2 The Karnataka Platform Based Gig Workers (Social Security and Welfare) Act, 2025, sections 20 and 21, and the Labour Department's notification fixing the fee, read at source through a legal publisher's reproduction of the government order's own table: one per cent of each payout within a statutory band of one to five per cent, with per-transaction caps of fifty paise for two-wheeler ride-hailing, food and grocery delivery and two-wheeler logistics, seventy-five paise for three-wheelers, one rupee for four-wheelers and light commercial vehicles and one rupee fifty for heavy vehicles and professional activity providers; rates applying from 13 February 2026 on a notification issued on the 16th. **Sources differ on whether the Act commenced in May or September 2025; this page prints no commencement date. The arithmetic showing the cap binding above fifty rupees, and the 0.2 per cent effective rate on a five-hundred-rupee fare, is this desk's.** 3 The approximately ₹4 crore deposited for the April-to-June 2026 quarter by the six named platforms, the Advocate General's undertaking, the state's own ₹250–300 crore projection, the fifteen registered platforms and the roughly seven lakh registered workers, and Zomato's ₹2.40 platform-fee increase of March 2026, all read at source in MediaNama's report of 28 August 2026, the most careful outlet on this beat. 4 The state legislation sequence and the dates of the December 2025 strike, the ministry's withdrawal of the ten-minute threshold on 13 January 2026 and Eternal's share move that afternoon, read at source in Indian trade and policy reporting; the forty-thousand figure is the organiser's, given in a union interview of 14 January 2026 and attributed as such. **The ₹4 crore figure is single-sourced and is the number this essay rests on; the annualisation and the per-worker figure are this desk's arithmetic on it.**

Section 21 of the Karnataka Act creates something called the Payment and Welfare Fee Verification System. Telangana's Act, gazetted in April 2026, creates its twin in its own Section 21, and the Telangana wording is the one to read: all payments made to platform-based gig workers shall be mapped onto the system **on a real-time basis**, administered by the government, monitored by the board, every transaction's fee reported as it happens.[1]

The central government arrived at the same place from the opposite direction. The Social Security (Central) Rules of 8 May 2026 require aggregators to register new workers in real time or daily and to report exits in real time. **Tanveer Pasha**, who represents drivers on the Karnataka welfare board, gave away what the fight had been about when he noted, almost in passing, that the companies had been reluctant to share real-time data.[1]

What is being built is the first live, transaction-level register of informal income in a large economy. Not a survey; not an annual return; a feed. India has spent fifteen years laying the pipes to watch money move — the identity number, the instant payments system, electronic invoicing for goods and services tax — and platform payouts were among the last large pools of income the state could not see at the moment it was earned. Fifty paise is what it costs to install the tap.[2]

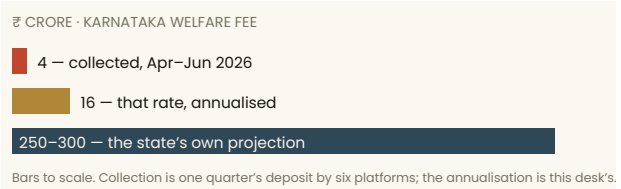
> ***"Less than one-third of the cess owed gets accounted."— V. V. Giri National Labour Institute and Indus Action, on thirty years of the construction-workers' cess, June 2026***[3]

Seen that way the three-cornered fight makes sense, which it otherwise does not. The Centre wrote its levy on **turnover** — annual, audited, arguable, and trivially gamed by a platform that books a hundred-rupee transaction as twenty rupees of commission. Six years after Parliament passed it, the rate has still not been notified; as of **18 October 2026** the electronic gazette carried nothing under the section. The states wrote theirs on the **transaction** — instantaneous, metered, uncontestable.[2]

Then two things happened that only a fight about a tax base explains. In September the platforms' own lobby went to the Union labour ministry and asked it to abandon turnover. And in the Karnataka High Court, the Union government's own Additional Solicitor General appeared *for the petitioners*, arguing that the state Act stands in "direct conflict" with the central Code. That is not a government defending workers from companies. It is a government defending a tax base it has not yet learned to collect.[4]

THE CHATTER · WHAT INDIA'S PLATFORM UNIONS SAY ABOUT THE WELFARE FEE

The unions wanted a bigger number and got the floor. **Inayat Ali**, who leads the Karnataka App-based Workers' Union, says they asked for two to five per cent; one per cent is inadequate. **Vinay Sarathi** of the United Food Delivery Partners' Union, who sits on the board, calls the board and the fee much needed and in the same breath describes what they do not touch: pay revised without announcement, identities terminated on a single customer complaint with no investigation, none of the dispute rights a factory worker has. **Shaik Salauddin** of the Telangana union puts the test on the companies' own numbers — if a hundred crore is being spent on worker welfare, why are injured riders not getting their insurance paid.[5]



A *Meridian* original, drawn from the figures in note 3 on p25.

SOURCES 1 Section 21 of the Karnataka Platform Based Gig Workers (Social Security and Welfare) Act, 2025, creating the Payment and Welfare Fee Verification System, and Section 21 of the Telangana Act No. 21 of 2026, creating the Welfare Fund Fee Verification System, whose real-time mapping requirement is quoted from the Act's own text, extracted from the legislature's published copy. **That copy is a scan and parts of its Section 20 did not resolve legibly, so no Telangana rate is printed here.** The real-time registration and exit-reporting duties from the Social Security (Central) Rules, 2026, notified 8 May 2026, read at source. Tanveer Pasha's remark as reported on 27 January 2026 when the Karnataka board was constituted, read at source. 2 The turnover base and the one-to-two per cent band are in section 114(4) of the Code on Social Security, 2020, brought into force 21 November 2025, read at source through a tax publisher's reproduction; the finding that no notification under that section appeared in the electronic gazette as of 18 October 2026 is reported at source by that publisher, dated 19 October 2026. The characterisation of the register and the comparison with the identity, payments and invoicing systems are this desk's argument. 3 V. V. Giri National Labour Institute and Indus Action, white paper published June 2026 from a workshop of June 2025, read as a document, for the quoted section heading and for the construction-cess figures used on p27. 4 The industry white paper submitted to the Union labour ministry on 29 September 2026 urging abandonment of the turnover base is **single-sourced** and is reported, not verified. The Additional Solicitor General's appearance for the petitioners and his "direct conflict" submission, read at source in MediaNama's report of 7 July 2026. 5 Inayat Ali and Vinay Sarathi as reported on 28 August 2026 and 27 January 2026 respectively, read at source; Shaik Salauddin in a union interview published 14 January 2026, read at source. Positions are summarised in this desk's own words from those reports; **no quotation here is reconstructed, and where a speaker is paraphrased it is marked by the absence of quotation marks.**

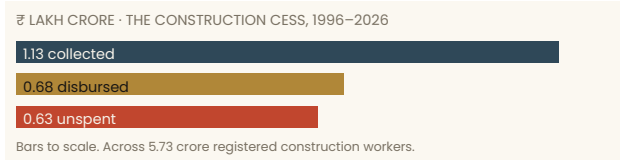
There is a precedent, and it is exact. In 1996 India created a cess on construction of **one to two per cent** — the same band the Code on Social Security now uses for aggregators — with a state welfare board, a dedicated fund, a register of workers and schemes to be framed by rules. Thirty years on, a white paper written for the labour ministry itself by the V. V. Giri National Labour Institute and Indus Action records the result: **₹1.13 lakh crore** collected, about **₹68,000 crore** disbursed, and nearly **₹63,000 crore** sitting unspent against 5.73 crore registered construction workers.[1]

The same paper puts collection at under a third of what was owed: an estimated **₹53,097 crore** due in 2022–23, against **₹15,355 crore** actually collected. Its recommendations are the tell. It asks for a unified data hub, dashboards, programmatic integration with the national worker register, a digital passbook, project-level traceability — which is to say, it asks for precisely what the gig Acts were drafted with already inside them. The gig levy is the construction cess rebuilt with the data layer the construction cess never got.[1]

A cess is a tax; a fee is a charge for a service. Which one this is decides the constitutional case.— the distinction the statutes avoid, and the press ignores[2]

So what should a reader expect? Four things, and none of them is insurance. The per-transaction base wins, because it is the only base the state can meter and the only one the platforms will concede; the board notified on **30 October 2026** met this month to settle it. The caps move before the rate does, because a statute allowing five per cent is currently charging a fifth of one, and nobody is watching the paise. The fund does not get spent, because no scheme exists under the central section and the first quarter's collection is in a court registry. And the durable output is fiscal rather than social: once every payout is visible as it happens, gig income becomes withholdable, taxable and means-testable. Swiggy already reports helping more than fifty thousand delivery partners file tax returns inside its own application.[2]

The argument, in one line: India is not insuring its gig workers. It is metering them, and the price of the meter is fifty paise an order. That is cheap formalisation — no reclassification fight, no employer liability, no minimum wage, just a tap and a rounding error — which is exactly why it will be copied, and why the copies will arrive wearing the word welfare.[2]



A *Meridian* original, from the figures in note 1.

THE SCEPTIC · THE CASE THAT INDIA'S GIG LEVY IS SMALLER THAN IT LOOKS

Nothing has been collected at scale, nothing has been paid out, and the state version may not survive. Uber's petition pleads that Parliament has occupied the field, and the Union government is arguing the same side; if repugnancy succeeds, the per-transaction levies fall and the meter with them. The eligibility gate is worse than the money: ninety days with one aggregator or a hundred and twenty across several, when platform disclosures suggest the average delivery partner works fewer than forty days a year — a levy on everyone funding benefits for almost nobody. The institution is already thinning, too: **Uber, Eternal and Porter resigned from the Karnataka board** rather than sit under a law they are challenging. **What would settle it:** the November board's decision on the base, and the first scheme actually notified.[3]

The question to carry out of it is not whether fifty paise is enough. It is what a government does with a live feed of fifty million people's earnings once it has one — and whether anybody thought to ask before the tap went in.[2]

SOURCES 1 V. V. Giri National Labour Institute and Indus Action, white paper published June 2026 from a workshop held 25 June 2025 and intended for the Ministry of Labour and Employment, read as a document, for the one-to-two per cent cess, the ₹1.13 lakh crore collected, the approximately ₹68,000 crore disbursed, the nearly ₹63,000 crore unutilised, the 5.73 crore registered workers, the ₹53,096.87 crore estimated due in 2022–23 against ₹15,354.86 crore collected, the quoted section heading on p26, and the list of recommendations. **Other sources give different unspent totals for different dates; this page uses the named institutional paper whose collection and disbursement figures reconcile to its own residual.** 2 The National Social Security Board for gig and platform workers was notified on 30 October 2026 with twenty-two members and a requirement to meet at least three times a year, read at source; its meeting in the second half of November and a reported pivot to a two per cent per-transaction levy are **single-sourced and reported, not verified** — this page says the board met to settle the base and prints no rate. The eligibility thresholds and the absence of any notified scheme are from the Social Security (Central) Rules, 2026, read at source. Swiggy's figure of more than fifty thousand delivery partners enabled to file returns is from its own quarterly shareholder letter for the quarter ended 30 September 2026; **the document exceeded this desk's fetch limit and the figure is taken from extracts of its own tables, so it is attributed and flagged.** The forecasts and the closing argument are this desk's. 3 Uber's petition and its repugnancy plea, read at source in Indian legal reporting of 28 July 2026; the resignations of the three platforms from the Karnataka board as reported on 28 August 2026, read at source; the observation that platform disclosures imply an average well under forty working days a year, and its consequence for the ninety-day gate, as set out by MediaNama in its report on the central Rules, read at source.

THE LAST WORD

Not yet in force

Turkey's parliament bound the country to defend Saudi Arabia and Pakistan by 279 votes to 119, on a text whose own second article says it takes effect when it appears in the official gazette. This desk read the gazette for the sixth, the seventh and the eighth of November. It is not there (p4).

It is the shape of the whole book. Israel's president announced on Saturday night that he will hand over the mandate this evening, and not before (p4). Singapore has restrained more than seven hundred million dollars and charged nobody in connection with it (p5). India passed an aggregator levy in 2020 and still has not notified the rate, which is why five states built their own meter instead (p25). Futures put seventy-three per cent on a rate rise that has not happened, and the bond market spent the week pricing an oil price rather than a central bank (p14).

The smaller ones rhyme. A craft recommended for inscription, pending a committee in Xiamen in December (p15). A crane taken off the endangered list, whose feeding stations are withdrawn a winter at a time (p21). A cabin shown to photographers that nobody will sit in before late 2027 (p19). Six restaurants open and not one reviewed (p24). And a holiday today whose Monday counts only if your rest day fell on it (p5). Decided is not done, and the gap is where most of a week lives.

TWELVE DESKS · ONE WORLD

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A note on method. Read at source this edition: the *Resmî Gazete*'s own issues of 6, 7 and 8 November; the United States Treasury's daily par and real yield curves; the Federal Reserve's, European Central Bank's and Bank of Japan's rate statements; the Bureau of Labor Statistics' October release; the Singapore Police Force's releases and the Ministry of Manpower's holiday page; MI's breach notice; Ballotpedia's tally; AMD's and Qualcomm's filings; Samsung's developer plans page; Phillips' lot pages; Box Office Mojo's daily chart; two journals' deposited abstracts and a trial registry; the Hokkaido crane census; the Japan Meteorological Agency's sea-ice diagnostic; Japan's culture agency and UNESCO's nomination file; and Karnataka's and Telangana's own statutes. **Refused this desk: Reddit entirely, across every desk in this issue; UKMTO, Lloyd's List, Burpple, the Michelin Guide's listings, Changi Airport Group's newsroom, Marina Bay Sands, the Singapore data-protection commission's decisions register, the exchange's own rate-probability tool, and both Japanese domestic airport timetables. Where a source refused, this book says so on the page rather than borrowing someone else's summary.**